

I: Association

It Broke. This is How.

David

Flashback

It's always five.

One. David is a little boy riding on Daddy's shoulders, and Lila's holding Daddy's hand, and together they find a part of the yard where they can peer past the branches into the clear and starry sky. Kyle's been teaching them the constellations. He names Cassiopeia, and Lila points out the "W" drawn by five stars. He tells them about Perseus, and Andromeda, and the creature of the deep they faced together because of the arrogance of Cassiopeia. Lila asks if Andromeda gets to fight the monster. David asks if they have to kill it.

Two. Lila makes it home from the vet before their parents. She finds David, a freshman, sitting on his bed, his puffy red eyes fixed on his hands. She whispers, "David," and his first instinct is to kick the door shut. But she lingers. She says his name again, softer. The door opens and he sags into her waiting hug. They stand there crying till their parents get home. There isn't anything they can say, except when they hear the front door open and David manages to confess, "I couldn't go with you." Lila shushes him, assures him that it's okay. That it's over. That Giddy looked so peaceful in the end. David says he's sorry. Lila repeats that it's okay to hurt.

Three. Mom and Dad are having the weekly family call with Lila, off at college, after supper while David is trying to finish his homework. Lila mentions somewhere she went that week instead of one of her evening classes, and almost immediately the call turns into an argument. Mom says, "You can make your own choices, honey, but we're not paying your tuition so you can neglect your studies." Without really looking up from his textbook, David tells his sister goodnight and removes himself to his room. On his way up he hears Lila ask if they wanted her to lie.

Four. Lila brings a guy home for Thanksgiving. Montgomery Alexander Rutherford Kensington (Mark) is a charming, chill, and startlingly rich trust fund kid. He's an instant hit and it's mutual. Within weeks he's part of the Adamson household's DNA, not by some great virtuosity but because he treats them all with such a genuine regard. They forget, for a while, the friction with Lila running underneath the surface. But like so many omens that have bubbled out into naked misfortune throughout his youth, David feels an unease growing right along with the Adamson family's bond with Mark. He doesn't bring it up with Lila, because she is growing increasingly distracted by Mark, school, work, her activism, and anything else that keeps her from having to spend too much time with their parents. David's busy too, trying to sneak his way through his last two years of high school without anyone noticing that he has no idea what to do with himself. The pressure builds.

Five. David's in the kitchen washing dishes while Lila tosses her life out with the trash. That's how Mom frames it later, anyway. She follows Lila outside like a frost nipping at her daughter's heels. Jenna Adamson does not say, "Don't walk away from me." Why would she? She's ice, and every glimpse of the frigid line of her spine aligning with the unbent corners of her mouth sets Lila on fire.

What do they say out in the snow? Lila slams the trash can opened and closed. She gets something on her fingers and dry-washes her hands before burying them in her jacket pocket. Is it about the ring, or Dad's birthday, or about how Lila has slowly edged herself out of the family? When the shouting starts, they're talking about him. Then the shouting cuts off, and Lila takes off. She leaves Mark behind; she goes blazing out into the night. A few miles down the road she pulls over and puts on her jacket and cries.

It gets real still at the Adamson house that night Lila leaves. The stillness starts almost before she's gone. It's like the storm of her fiery argument with Mom and the ice-knife severance from Mark are only the final tuning notes of cacophony before the hush when the conductor raises his baton, but what should have been a quiet pause becomes the whole performance. David, cursed constant spectator, punctuates that performance by turning the water off, dishes in the sink half-done, and taking fifteen measured steps from the kitchen to the door of his room. The door creaks open, he slips inside, and the latch clicks. It doesn't slam, but like the rest of the trappings for this evening it feels final.

The pressure in his room is different from that in the common spaces of the house, but the theatrical stillness still mutes the world. David steps around a pile of his clothes on the floor and places himself cross-legged in the middle of his bed. He pulls out his phone but leaves it in his lap at first. A breath. One. Two. Three. Four. He holds it longer than he maybe should. His attempt to break the performance is deliberate, methodical, and somehow fruitless. He dials his sister's number digit by digit rather than tap her name from the two-item list of favorite contacts. He presses the screen where it displays an icon of a green phone, and a ringtone perforates Lila's sail.

She picks up.

"You know, you didn't actually say good-bye," he says.

Lila performs stillness while she swallows her sobbing.

David says, "I wanna say something that doesn't suck. Don't know what to say to help you right now. But—"

"David," Lila says.

He says, "Can you keep in touch? I won't let Mom know."

"Little brother, this is not your fault."

"I know," David says, "But I'm paying for it."

"Do you want me to apologize?"

"Want you not to leave."

A stretching silence.

"I need to figure this out for myself, and it'll keep getting worse if I stay. We're all just hurting each other."

"You weren't hurting me."

Lila eventually says, "Don't worry, I'll call you. But it's gonna be crazy for me for a while."

"You'll figure it out. You always figure it out."

"Thanks. I gotta get back on the road now."

"Text me when you're back safe."

She hangs up. He doesn't see her again, in person, until after she dies.

The Path That Leads Home

Starlight kissed my hand

A last breath expelled

From a distant grave

Danced every possible path

To graze my knuckle

Lila	Assorted
 *	  

Jenna Adamson leans against her kitchen counter, a phone pressed against her ear. There's a broad, arched window in front of the sink with a full view of the back yard. Jenna watches her son recline in his hammock, strung up for the day between two maples that have been straining for dominance of the back yard for forty years. David is devouring another fantasy novel, some tale of daring feats and the conspiracy of fate, but at least he's doing it while soaking up the first hours of real sunlight for the year. It's unseasonably warm, but you don't look a gift horse in the mouth like that.

The phone is ringing. It will ring five times, then go to voicemail. Jenna has already tried to call twice in the last few minutes. She wants to hear her daughter's voice, yes even if it's still raw with accusation, because it is her daughter's voice. The phone rings five times, but those rings seem to stretch out towards the edge of the known universe. It's long enough for Jenna to stare at one of her children and think of the other and feel the blossom of her love for them soak in the rays of hope that they will be happy. It's long enough for the stretching to make her think of Lila staring at the night sky's countless beckoning stars with her father, expounding for another hour on the sheer incredible scale of all that there is, its unknowable but nearly measured distance. It's long enough she can mentally recite what she's going to say if Lila picks up. It's long enough she imagines, without really wanting to, rebuilding the bridge between herself and her daughter.

It's long enough that, unlike with the last two tries, Jenna is too absorbed in thought to hang up once the call does go to voicemail. She says, "I wish you didn't leave." Then, startled, she hangs up.

Lila sits in the theater for a while after the movie ends. She appreciates the credits, and the space they give her to dry her eyes and collect herself. After, as she strides out into the warm, quiet light of the theater hall and turns off airplane mode she sees she has a voicemail from her mother. It's three seconds long. She sees the auto-transcript as she's deleting it. It feels like a javelin that comes thrumming through the empty space between her arm and her heart. Lila straightens her spine and heads back to her apartment.



Every Friday night, Kyle Adamson sits on their porch-swing and rocks himself. He stares up at the sky. For the first couple months, it's very cloudy and he can't see the stars. Eventually, though, he gathers their twinkling lights into his heart. Every Friday night, he calls Lila.

She doesn't answer him, but that doesn't stop him from leaving messages. He says he misses his little girl, that they all miss her. He tells her about what's been going on in their lives. He tells her he trusts her. He knows she's got to get her own life in order if she's going to run the whole show some day. And he says he's proud.

A part of Lila reaches back out to him, but she can't call him back. Not yet. Not until she gets it sorted out, like he says.



Any sort of dog that has shepherd in its pedigree, like Spark, needs an outlet for its energy. Thankfully, Sandra likes to walk her dog. She enjoys the variation in the weather, though it has been a little hot in the summers the last couple years. She clings to the adage that in Michigan, "if you don't like the weather just wait five minutes." She doesn't put much more thought into it than that. The rainy spring day with an umbrella, some baggies, and a leash on a city sidewalk suits Sandra just fine. She smiles and says hello to folks on her way.

Then a girl about her age comes up the sidewalk. She's talking as fast as she's walking, her eyes glazed over while she plies whoever it is on the other line with what sounds like answers to job interview questions. Sandra plans to mind her own business, get off to the side with her dog and continue on her day. But Spark doesn't like the look of the girl's scarf, or the way she smells, or something, because he strains against his leash and starts barking his head off. Sandra calls Spark to heel, but he's not very well trained and won't hear her over the sound of his defensive reaction to the lady on her phone.

"God." Phone-girl sneers into her phone. She stops, then picks her way around past the radius of Spark's leash. She says, "No, sorry, someone's dog's just going feral on the sidewalk."

"Excuse me what," Sandra says.

Phone-girl rolls her eyes and keeps walking and talking.

Sandra calls out, "Don't talk about my dog like that!" She kneels down by Spark's head and nuzzles him. Scratches behind the ears. There's a good boy. Forget that rich girl. Yeah, you're such a good boy Sparky.

Lila, disappearing around the corner, still fixated on landing this position, feels a stab of shame. It gets tangled in a knot of memory, a room at the Vet and a brother in tears at home, and she shoves that all in a box for Future Lila to deal with later.

She gets an in-person interview. She doesn't get the job.



Mark sits on a couch. It's Lila's couch; the one she picked out to go in the living room of their house—this house he bought and fixed up for them. Had fixed up, he corrects himself. Sure, he did a little of the demolition, and made the aesthetic calls, and paid for it, but it was the contractors who

did the work that gave this place its value. It aches to practice that mindfulness, because it reminds him that she taught him the perspective, to think about where his money came from and where it was going and how his procession through life affected the people surrounding him. Lila taught him to practice being kind and doing good with what he had. The ache deepens: she taught him so much like that, then she cut herself loose from everyone.

The walls are a pleasant and abiding green in the living room they were going to share. The matte, brownish gray of the couch contributes toward the cozy earthen atmosphere they wanted. There's other rooms in this house that are already painted, but not furnished. The upstairs is like a blank slate. The planning itself was unfinished. It was a recent obsession that led to Mark pushing everything up to the point they'd gotten to with their planning before she broke it off.

Mark sits in the dark except for the light of his phone. He keeps thinking maybe he should call her and then keeps not trying. She doesn't have him blocked. She just won't answer.

He should probably finish the house. Make his own choices about the rest of the rooms, maybe erase the parts she planned, and actually live here. Or he should sell it, or give it away. Make a halfway house, or something. That's what she would tell him to do, if she found out he'd been sitting on empty, perfectly good housing for months. Maybe she'd even tell him to rent it out. That's what his dad would assume he'd do with the property: make some income off of it.

Mark doesn't need more income.

Is this why she left him? Is he too indecisive, too inactive? He doesn't do enough, fast enough, to improve the lives of the communities around him? Or is it because in her eyes it will never be enough to wash away the taint of the exploitation that extracted his father's many millions?

For the first time in six months, he gets a call. It's her. He picks up immediately.

"Hey," he says. He has to choke down calling her "love." "What's up?"

"I'm coming back to see my family," Lila says. Her voice is sharp.

"That's great, Li!"

"I don't want to see you there."

Mark says, "Okay. You won't."

"David says you still hang around. Making nice." An accusation.

Mark's free hand rubs the fabric of the empty couch seat next to him. He yearns for her to be beside him, where he can face her and soak her presence up like sunlight. He says, "I still like your family, Li."

"Are you gonna give me the same shit about David needing a man in his life?"

"I am not your mother."

The sound of Lila taking a deep breath. "Look, I... maybe I was stupid. I need to talk to Mom and Dad and I don't need you as a distraction."

"Li," Mark says, "I already said I won't be there. When are you coming?"

"Not sure yet."

"And hey, you didn't tell me being with your family was off limits. I would have respected that, if that was what you wanted."

Lila practically growls into the phone. "You know what she's like."

"She's not like that all the time," Mark says. "And maybe my being there has helped her understand a bit. Where we come from."

"Never mind," Lila says. "I don't want to talk about her."

A long pause. She doesn't hang up right away.

Mark asks, "How've you been doing? David says you don't tell him much."

"What's there to tell him? That there's no jobs out there? I've got some applications lined up for some programs, but..."

"Still can't decide if you want to crunch the numbers or pour out the words?"

"We already had that talk. I can't afford to do both. There's not enough of me to go around."

"Context was different then," Mark says. "Because it seemed like, Before, you were okay with my solution. I can afford it for you."

"Yeah but you can't afford a cloning machine, can you?"

"I'm still trying to wrap my head around this, Li. There's not enough of you to go around, so you shut everyone out and try harder to do it all yourself?"

Another pause. "Why do you think I'm going home? What the hell do I think I'm doing, Mark?"

"You're trying," he says without hesitation. "We're all trying."

"Yeah," Lila says, trailing off.

"Am I going to have to wait another six months for you to call me again? Even as a friend?"

"I don't know," she says. "I hope not."



David is already cleaning when his sister calls. His earbuds are in, pulsing music directly into his ears from a station that fits his mood. He's got the trash can pulled out from its corner while he sweeps. After that it'll be the wet work. He feels like he needs both things: the music internalizes what he's feeling; the work externalizes what he wants. Doesn't matter how long that cobweb's been left standing in the corner between the toilet and the brush in its stand. A swish timed with a dark cymbal crash, and it's gone now. The music is cut off mid-riff by Lila's ringtone, the opening of a different song where a solo flute plays a fore-ghost of the song's melody low in its register. David snatches his phone up out of his pocket and answers before the drums break in.

"Hey, Li," he says.

"Hey," she says. Once it's clear the call is solid, he drops his phone back into his pocket. She's in his ear.

"In the middle of cleaning," David says. "Sorry if the sound's a little off." He finishes sweeping and sets the broom aside. Time to break out the chemicals. He heads to the cabinet.

Lila says, "How are you doing?" Then, having detected something in her own tone, adjusts her affect to mock the over-earnestness of the first question. "Have you had any water today?"

As he grabs some cleaner and the sponge for the sink, David makes a face at the rest of the supplies. "I've had plenty."

There's a light, nervous chuckle on the other end of the call. "Sorry."

David asks, "To what do I owe the pleasure of your call, dear sister?" He flicks the water on long enough to wet his sponge, then pours some soap onto it.

She says, a little off-beat, "Just wanted to talk."

He scrubs around the drain stopper. "So is that hesitation I hear more sororal concern for my well being or is there something else that's up?"

She pauses again. David spreads suds on the stainless steel faucet head. He spreads them onto the handles. It's silent except for breathing and scrubbing. He briefly resents the absence of his music.

Finally, Lila says, "I think I might be coming home for a day or two."

David turns the water on full blast. He wets the sponge enough that there's hardly soap left in it, then uses it to rinse the faucet. He dips his finger into the stream, making the water split around it. It's not hot right away.

He says, "Mom and Dad aren't here this weekend. Marriage retreat."

"Oh," she says.

"Probably good timing. We could make some popcorn and binge a season of something?" Water's still cold. What is it about the upstairs faucets in this house that makes them take so long to heat up?

"I... wanted to talk to them."

David squeezes the water out of the sponge and sets it next to the sink to dry. He steps back over to the open cabinet and pulls out the toilet bowl cleaner.

"That's a surprise." After it comes out of his mouth it feels like a lie. He'd felt the pinch building up in his chest before she called. No, couldn't be that. Why would he dread getting to see his sister again? He twists the cap on the toilet bowl cleaner and douses the bowl. Has to be something else.

"Just like me leaving?" she asks.

David's hand closes on the handle of the toilet brush. Her leaving hadn't been a surprise. It had been a dam breaking, and it had broken around David's fingers while he tried to plug the holes.

She's trying to be conciliatory, using the same self-critical affect as when she asked if he'd been hydrating. It's a tone like she knows she's voicing something that could just go unspoken between them, but she is trying to express instead her openness to his honest assessment. Trying to (gently) goad him into blaming her for leaving, if he does. For his sake? For hers? As a practice run for their parents?

He asks, "Are you sure you're ready?"

"Does it matter?"

Something about those words makes it push in tighter. Is it frustration that his sister can't seem to go about conflict the quiet way? It's always loudly in your face or loudly slamming the door on the way out. Is it worry over how Mom and Lila might approach the chance for a reconciliation like a pair of freight trains headed for a collision? Those things bother him, sure, but he's never felt the pressure this intensely before. Like he's waiting to be struck.

This particular chemical is supposed to sit in the toilet for a few minutes to soften things up before you get to scrubbing. David sets right in without waiting. It's that or let the cinching curl his knees and arms against his chest and roll him across the bathroom floor.

"Hey," Lila says after another pause. She's quiet. Is he breathing too hard? "You okay?"

"I'm fine," he lies, then corrects to: "I'll be fine. Doesn't usually..." Another sensation rises, a tingling that starts at the base of his neck and spreads goosebumps across his skin. This one, he knows the source of. Don't notice me. Don't worry about me. Don't waste your time on me. I'm fine. I'm...

"David, I'm sorry. I—"

"It's not you." David huffs out a breath (not a sob, not yet), scrubs under the rim, and changes the subject. "Do you still want to come home this weekend, or are you waiting for Mom and Dad to be back?"

"Hold on," Lila says. "If it's not me then what is it? Please, I want you to be able to talk to me."

David stands up. The toilet brush drips into the toilet. "It's stupid. It's nothing."

Then anticipation of what's coming breaks into the panic of it happening. His soul gives? The source of the pressure drives like a spike into some load-bearing pillar of his selfhood, and the line connected to it pulls taut. It happens in an instant, happens so suddenly and completely it almost feels like it's always been there.

David somehow has time, even as the bolt of that transgression strikes, to cling to the thought that Lila has something to say to him. He wants—No. He insists on hearing what she says. So it is that a young man's panicked assertion siphons some of the paradigmatic flow of reality as it shunts him across realms. When he appears out of context amid the flames of a smoldering study, his phone call with Lila Adamson does not end.

In his ear, his sister says, "You're not nothing, David Adamson."



Lila makes the call from her car after getting back from the store. The car is parked but still running to keep her cool. She sits in relative stillness while her brother occupies his hands, listening to his growing anxiety with her own deepening concern.

She knows that he doesn't want her to notice, even castigates herself for worrying over him like their mother does, constantly fretting that he's not coping well and at the same time never countenancing the idea that maybe David should get some help. Because, of course, why would he need it? He's so productive, he graduated in the top ten of his high school, and he never complains. He's an upper middle class white kid. He's fine. He just has to figure himself out. But what if figuring himself out looks anything like how Lila has been figuring herself out?

She decides, mid-call, that she would rather try to help David somehow than have the call be about her. He doesn't want to open up. He belittles himself. And she tells him that he's not nothing.

At first Lila thinks that the tenuous connection she feels, tethering them across what she thinks is 50 miles, is just her love for her brother. It makes her feel like maybe he'll hear her assert his value, and how much she means it, but the response that she gets sounds more like a gust of wind. Then a grunt, and a crackle as an earbud falls out of his ear and lands on stone.

"David?" she asks. She sits forward in her seat, cranking the AC down to nothing so the fans don't interfere with what she can hear.

There are mumbled, incoherent questions that come in David's voice from the other line, then more static.

A distant voice says, "Who are you?" There is something about the voice, and not just that it's a stranger's, that unsettles her. It's a man's voice, sonorant, but with nothing of the tenor that Mark or her Dad's voice carries. And there is that something else, some strange slipknot of meaning tied around the words. The voice, closer now, continues, "What is this?"

Lila says, "David! What's happening?"

His answer is garbled and sounds almost like choking.

She puts her phone on speaker and mounts it. She throws the car in reverse and all but peels out in the parking lot. It's a little less than an hour's drive to their parents' house if she goes the speed limit. She'll get there in twenty five minutes.

First Turn of the Coin



Feeling it coming isn't enough to prepare David for instant meta-dimensional transit. There's no portal to stumble through or stars skewing into relativistic lines. There's not a waiting room or dial tone, unless that horrible buildup to the piercing of his innermost self counted for that. White fluorescent bathroom lighting blinks out into dim firelight, and the shift in brightness blinds David till his eyes can adjust. The pressure in the tower room is much different from the family bathroom as well, and that is just as jarring. It knocks out his equilibrium, which throws him to the floor and tosses loose one of his earbuds. Somehow, though the stone is rough under his knees and palms and he lands in a drift of some sort of hot flaky powder, it doesn't hurt when he hits the ground.

Lila says his name. Maybe he tries to answer. He's too dissociated to know quite what he's doing. Someone here moves towards him, also speaking.

David's mind is anything but empty. It's a cacophony of half-parsed stimuli and untamed snippets of cognition. He tries to grasp something, physical or internal, that he can use to stagger to his literal or metaphorical feet, but all of his thoughts skitter and buzz about in his skull, harrying his executive function but intangible when he snatches at them.

His eyes finish adjusting. They fix on the fragile glow of embers inches from his face. His fall must have stirred them up. Ashes and a speckling of those embers coat his hands and most of his arms. There's an earbud-sized crater in a little pile of those ashes that's not far from his face, and the toe of a boot not two inches from the crater. Everything he sees is haunted by shadows from a torch that flickers above him.

Lila, her voice panicked, asks him what's happening. David looks up. There's a man (the one both the torch and the boot belong to) standing threateningly close to where David fell, and he's holding the headphone that fell out of David's ear. The man hears Lila's muffled voice emit from the earbud's speaker and looks concerned, but not startled. The man's fist closes around the earbud as if he's trying to crush it, prompting David to splutter a dazed attempt at a protest.

He hears the engine rev in Lila's car.

As he hears this David finds something he can crystallize his thoughts around, but he hates it. That heavy line with its anchor in his center is still pulled tight; it's tugging him towards some untraced direction. Before this time, the pinching dread has always broken into a burn that feels like a flower of fire, or it's condensed into a fist of ice that drops into his stomach. This time it's like getting punched through by an arrow on a grappling hook, and now whoever's on the other end is trying to haul him in. Those other times he's at least had the relief that it's over, and all that's left to deal with is the aftermath, however painful. Now, though, he's certain that whatever terrible thing (or string of them) had been coming isn't finished yet. He begs his stupid, hateful mess of a brain for something else to latch onto. Couldn't his sister's voice, a sense of justice, or blunt curiosity galvanize him instead? But no, in the sizzling haze of his mind there's only this: It's going to get worse. Fine. He snatches hold of that thought and climbs on top of it. He takes a breath, and *thank God* his brain lets him pay some attention to his surroundings.

He's in a stone room with a man and a woman who look almost confused as he feels. This room is doorless, windowless, and empty except two distinct piles of ashes and the three of them close enough to huddle up together. David is kneeling in one of the ash mounds, the water from his brush sizzling in a residual heat he feels as if from a distance. It's hot, but like a good shower hot. Not

enough to hurt. The man with the torch opens his fist to frown at David's earbud, which is somehow intact.

Lila says, "Stay on the line as long as you can. I'm coming."

The woman moves while the man is distracted, holding out a hand as if to calm the two of them. The man takes one precise step back. To David the woman looks, like, 39. She's wearing a short dark brown coat and slacks, both swarming with buttoned pockets (some of which are bulging). Her gesture draws David's eyes to the mask she holds in her warning hand: a full-face red falcon mask fashioned from feathers and polished wood. She holds the mask with two fingers at one bottom corner, her fingers poised with a care that suggests the mask is both precious to her and somehow more violent to carry than the sword in her other hand. She holds that sword at her side in a loose grip. It's covered in gold decoration. Her hair's in a crown braid; her posture implies an actual crown would belong just fine.

She says, "I did not expect this."

David tries to think of something he can say that would also give his sister some context. Even now after he's wrestled his way to attention his thoughts flow thick as syrup. David doesn't try to care about first impressions, but his body reacts in anticipation to making a first impression the way it would to a threat to his life. A ripple under his abiding anticipation of disaster is that he's already made himself look like an idiot. But there's no escaping it now, and at least they aren't laughing at him.

He settles, finally, on the cringe-inducing all-timer, "Where am I?" But it comes out as a croak, and he's not sure either Lila or the two in the room with him understand the question. Is it too hot in the room, or is the humidity difference between home and here so great it's screwing with his throat?

The man with the torch¹ is in uniform, something white and pristine, but the thing he's holding that seemed like a torch at first is burning all the way down to an oval-shaped cross-guard. So not a torch; it's a sword that's on fire. That tracks with the ash heaps. The sword-flames are the only source of light in the room.

Forgetting the headphone now that David has spoken, the man now stares at David like you watch the road for deer after one darts in front of your car. Then the man's face sinks fractionally. His eyes flick down. They tag the woman before fixing on David again to be sure he hasn't moved. He says, "I don't feel him." His voice, urgent, hitches when he says "him." It doesn't sound like he's talking about David. "The Circle?"

She says, "The bonds are just scattered."

"And this lad?" The man gestures with his firebrand. Since there's no other light in this room, the way the light shifts with the gesture feels a little like a floodlight pinpointing David. It's that gesture that cements in David's mind that this guy is a cop. Officer Firesword it is.

She doesn't answer Firesword. Instead she disappears that falcon mask into one of her countless pockets, then leans the tip of her sword into the stone and lowers herself to her knees in front of David. Her head is frighteningly close to the flames of the soldier's weapon, and that makes half her face disappear into shadows.

She asks, "Are you well?"

¹Also, like, 39-ish, or maybe just a seen-some-shit 33.

Looking into that half face, drawn with somber lines of flickering orange-red light, reinforces David's conclusion that the worst is still coming. It has to be worse that she's being so careful and tense, right? As he reels with that, David's tongue stays locked behind his teeth.

Lila is talking in the earbud again. "Who is that?" she asks. "Is someone taking you somewhere? Please, get me some details!" She's not waiting long enough for him to find a way to answer, and Firesword glances again at the headphone he's still holding. David draws another deep breath of smoky air. It doesn't make him feel like he has to cough, but he coughs anyway. Then he slides his phone out of his pocket to change the call settings from his earbuds to speakerphone.

The growl from Lila's laboring engine bursts into the chamber from the phone's speaker.

The woman blinks. The firelight bobs as Firesword tries to gesture for the woman to stand up and back away from David. David watches them, unblinking, thinking. Almost absently, he sets his phone on the floor in front of him, plucks out the earbud that was still in his ear, and tucks it away in its case.

The man says, "What are these instruments?" He waggles the headphone between his fingers and then gestures with the same hand towards the phone and the case David just put in his pocket. "Where are those sounds coming from?"

Can he say something bold and clever enough? Does it matter if they know for sure that he's connected to someone far away (maybe even worlds away)? Lila's going to think she can still help him unless he can convince her that he's been whisked somewhere impossible for her to reach. But he doesn't know if he can put the words for that together fast enough to say them before the situation sweeps past his chance to affect it.

"David?" Lila asks, this time her voice ringing fully into the chamber.

"It's—" David's voice creaks, so he clears his throat and tries again. "That's my sister."

Something clicks for Officer Firesword. He mutters, "Ambergris." A curse, the way he says it. He looks to the woman, who shakes her head.

"I would know if he had stolen the Circle's bonds. This is something else."

"But it is similar." Firesword sounds like he's driving at something else. Looking for some terrible confirmation.

The woman seems to steel herself. She looks David in the eyes again and says, "I am called Mere. Please... David?" She pauses to see his nod confirm the name. "I'm so sorry, David, but please, if you can answer me this: are there many people in the land you and your sister are from?"

Lila's voice is a whip-crack, "Why?"

Firesword curses again.

"Unless we are swift," Mere answers, "they are all doomed."

David squeezes his eyes shut.

"Doomed by what?" Lila asks.

He doesn't see what Mere and Officer Firesword do, but they're quiet. It feels like they're watching him. Expecting him to respond to Mere's pressure.

Lila doesn't wait for David. She says, "What. Did. You. Do."

But it's still quiet after, and Lila is going to get nowhere with them like this. Swimming through the turmoil of his mind, the only thing he finds to cling to is still that one punctured pillar binding

him to the Worse that's coming. David makes what he concludes to be his only choice, to the mild shock and utter heartbreak of those who witness it. He opens his eyes and stands (leaving the toilet brush in the ashes, but not his phone) and shakily says, "Okay. What do you need me to do?"

Mere stands with him. The shock, and the new fault line it leaves in its wake, she quickly spackles over with the blank of business. She says, "Come with me," and turns away.

"I'd ask where," David says, "but I don't see how it would make a difference."

"David!" Lila hisses. "What are you doing? Don't go anywhere with them!"

He holds the phone up near his mouth and whispers, "I'm somewhere else already, Li." He taps the button to shift the call to video. The phone pulses in his hand. There's a quick pop-up that reads: *Video calling is currently unavailable.*

As they're talking, Mere draws a line with the tip of her sword on one wall of the room. A door appears within the border of that line. It must stand almost ten feet from the floor to the ceiling, and it is formed entirely from a dark and glossy wood. Where the handle should be, there is a large gilded keyhole. David records a video of the whole process, murmuring his commentary to Lila.

The man with the burning sword says, "I would also like to know where we are going."

"I had thought you would guess," Mere says, sliding her sword into the door's keyhole. It goes in up to the hilt, which in turn now looks like an overly long doorknob.

The man says, "I want to hear it."

Mere turns the hilt-knob. "I'd like to consult your husband."

The door creaks open. The man asks, "Is that wise?"

"The boy is bound for the Sword regardless."

"Hey!" Lila's voice peaks the speaker. "Don't touch my brother!"

The man with the burning sword cocks his head at David. His brow creases. "Is she in the same place you were in before you arrived here?"

David says no, but she's on her way.

The man says, "Warn her off."

Mere looks between them, her arm still outstretched to hold a partially open portal to yet another elsewhere.

David takes a few steps to get a better angle at the opening the door just made in the room, but Officer Firesword stays on him, and the light from the sword obscures what might be beyond.

David asks, "Do we have time for questions?"

Mere answers, "On the way."

She starts to finish pulling the door open, but the man says, "Wait. I cannot tolerate it."

Mere waits.

Firesword aims his voice towards David's phone. "Do not go to where your brother was before. I believe a creature has taken his place, a man of fogged vision, unbending will, and hideous strength. If you encounter this man, he will unmake you."

"Sworn Sword," Mere says, voice heavy with regret. "We do not have time."

And she hauls the door open, showing David that the space beyond is black. David's first thought is that it's night on the other side, but as he and Firesword approach the doorway it becomes clear that instead it's a huge stone bridge in an endless teetering void. A short set of stairs connects their door to that bridge. Visible across the bridge is another set of stairs leading to a different door, glimmering and translucent.

Officer Firesword says, "Something is wrong."

"I agree this permutation is ominous," Mere says, "but Lenn awaits with our answers."

With a curt nod and no further complaint, the officer moves to usher David through the door after Mere.

David asks, "What's wrong with the Bridge?" They don't answer.

He follows Mere across the threshold. As he does, static hisses out of his phone's speakers.

"David, I think I'm losing—"

The call drops. She's gone. It happens in the same moment that Firesword's namesake winks out.

David loses his balance again immediately. There's no hand-rail on the steps leading down to the bridge, which seems like a great way to leave you a clumsy step away from an eternal fall into the nothing. David almost does just that, except that Firesword claps a hand on David's shoulder to steady him.

When David turns his head and looks up the bridge (or down it, how could you tell?) his eyes water. He locks his gaze on Mere's back instead. After the man with the until-recently-burning sword passes through the doorway, it closes out of existence. They feel it close, each imagining the soft click and the change in pressure, but as quickly as the resonance of the moment strikes it passes over them.

Firesword is dead-quiet. Not just non-verbal: his steps, breath, and clothing make no sound. His sword isn't even burning anymore.

David tries to keep his eyes fixed on Mere. She's two strides ahead, moving with the confidence of a captain walking the deck of her ship during a battle or a storm. There's tension there, but it's worn down into a kind of comfort. Here on this bridge, which draws David's mind out to lengths beyond sight and whose very existence sets David on edge, Mere is home. He tries to keep focused on that, but the weight of the bridge laid out in front of them draws his eyes up.

That hook, line, and sinking feeling which his sense of impending doom has become is aligned with the direction of the bridge. It tightens further as if in response to his noticing, to the point it feels like he'll be yanked off his feet any moment and go plummeting towards whatever waits at the end of the Bridge.

The hand on David's shoulder tightens, but the sensation is strange. It's like it's Firesword's fingers that give, the way David imagines what stone would feel when someone pushes on it, if a stone could feel.

David tries to draw a breath to speak, and realizes then that he cannot suck air into his lungs—that there is no air here for him to breathe—yet his intended words seem to sound even while his mouth is startled frozen. Those words ring in the abyssal dark around the bridge, "*I was going to ask questions.*" Struck by the strange sensation, he tries to force a chuckle, but there isn't even the shadow of laughter to escape him.

He says, *“Dear God there’s no air in here how am I talking scratch that how are my lungs not exploding what is this place and why is it so hollow?”*

“This is a Realm of Extension,” Mere says. *“It is shaped by the thoughts and wills of those who walk its path. Everything but the path itself is transient, here.”*

David means to say, “Oh,” but the thought that niggles in his mind in response is what sounds instead, *“But there’s nothing here except the path. And these doors.”*

As they continue, David takes note of the doors. There is a door of earthen reddish wood with brass ring handles, a gray fence-gate shrouded in fog, a once-broken iron door whose cracks are filled with gold, an open arch of flowers, and, for just a moment, a plain off-white door with something nailed to its face. When he tries to look closer at any of them, but especially the last one, the doors have vanished like they were never there.

Finally, Mere answers, *“There is some will suppressing the way that the realms normally mingle at the edges here. I trust it is not you, Sworn Sword?”*

The flavor of Firesword’s shifting, uncomfortable silence is that it is not him forcing the Bridge into a strangling, nihilistic blackness. He was the one of the two of them to point out that something was wrong, anyway. So why would Mere ask, unless it’s to make David wonder?

But David latches onto something else. *“That’s not your name, is it? Sworn Sword?”* He finds he prefers the strange nature of speech over crushing silence.

“It is a title: I am the Sworn Sword, an Arbiter of Ea’river.”

“I don’t think I can call you by a title. Can we do names? Mine is David. I’m from Earth, the place that her majesty just admitted is imminently doomed. You?”

The guy doesn’t answer.

“Doesn’t have to be your real name,” David says.

Still nothing.

“Fine, I’m calling you Mustang.” Both a little more and a little less on the nose than Firesword, David figures. Having taken that sip of levity, he gets back to the real questions. *“Why is my planet doomed?”*

An old cabin door, several of its planks shattered and the whole thing snapped off its hinges, passes them in the dark.

After Mustang pauses too long again, it’s Mere that answers. *“A man is strangling Veneth,”* she says. *“We undertook to dispel him from this realm with a curse. Though he seems to have been expelled, there appears to be one more step required to seal his exile.”*

“I appeared where he disappeared, so you think he will be in my place?”

“Until we complete the curse,” Mere says.

David thinks of his parents, safe at a retreat, and of his sister, probably ignoring Mustang’s warning and racing home for a date with a world-ending horror. He says, *“How do we do that?”*

“I have a suspicion,” Mere answers, *“but I want to confirm it with Lenn.”*

“Is that Mustang’s estranged husband?”

Mustang's fingers flex against David's shoulder again. There is the ghost of pressure in it, but only to a point. David detects it more from the guy's shift in posture than anything his shoulder feels. He wonders if his arm has gone numb, and turns to see Mustang's scowl.

Mustang is the picture of a stone-faced stoic. Except, he's not the kind of stoic who has naturally stunted emotions and expressions. He's one of the actual philosophical ones, one like David sometimes thinks he'd like to be, if he could master his own facial expressions. So Mustang has big tells peeking through that attempt at dour and statuesque. Firelight that isn't there anymore seems to dance in his eyes, painting passion plays of dread, worry, loss, and regret.

All right there, my guy, David thinks. I see you. I get it.

Mere says, *"Lenn drew out the terms for the curse. He will best know how we need to proceed."*

"Where does this Bridge lead?" David asks.

Mustang says, *"Its end."*

Mere says, *"To wherever one is headed, with some exceptions."*

"So I could find my way home from here?"

"If you knew where to look."

The stone feels like it turns beneath David's feet. He turns his head with the sensation, and swears that for a hot second he can see that white door again, the one with a poster on it, atop a set of carpeted stairs that have branched from the Bridge. When he looks closer for it, though, there's nothing.

David asks, *"Will you tell me how?"*

"There isn't time."

"Looks like a long walk."

Mere pauses. *"There is no time here."*

David says, *"Uh."*

"I said this is a realm of Extension. This is not a place the way the tower was. What illusions of flesh and presence you experience here are projections. When the thought of our passage is completed, so too will our arrival complete."

"I.. what? If we get there 'when' we get there, don't we have as much space for conversation as it takes?"

"You are already wandering dangerously," Mere says. "Say you are drawing an arrow in the sand on a beach. You have in mind to what the arrow should point, but you allow yourself to be distracted by an unusually large wave or the sounding of a gull. Your line not only wavers, but the arrow gestures askew, towards some other object you know not what, and the thought you meant to share is lost even before the tide can clear it from the sands."

"I will not be diverted from the course, so while I have permitted your questions so far I cannot stop to teach you all the wonder and peril of pathfinding the realms."

On queue for the end of that statement, David spots a shape in the distance: the outline of an enormous burning sword.

The Falcon Witnesses a Birth

Mere		
	Once	

Gist, the capitol of Naris, was the city of orchards and the seat of the gods. The city itself did not have high walls or gates, but it sported several palaces, the finest of which rose like a navel from the lowest point of the city. In the center of that palace, framed by copses of trees cultivated for the vibrant colors of their blossoms and the sweetness of their fruit, was the courtyard called the Forum of the Gods. It is there that the leaders of Naris, the gods-officiant masked in the likeness of the creatures that represented their Sacred Deeds, met to execute matters of state and discuss the prognosticated fates of their nation. The public was forbidden to set foot inside.

The orphan girl called Mere never intended to enter the Forum of the Gods. Let alone that it was forbidden, in her scraped-together life on the outskirts of Gist she scarcely knew such a place existed. She knew little more than where she planned to get her next meal, until one day she slipped while climbing a tree in an orchard near the city's edge to steal a fruit. When she landed, it was not into the brush under the eye of an angry arborist but onto gold-and-marble flagstones in plain view of all the gods.

This was, Mere would come to learn, interpreted as some kind of portent. It was never clear if the portent regarded her own fate or that of Naris. At the word of the Wolf God of Names and the Butterfly God of Dreams, Mere stood before the judgment of the gods and ate the fruit she'd plucked from the tree, sharing one bite with the god who was chosen to shepherd her from then forward: the Falcon God of Messengers.

There were some truly momentous things the gods chose not to tell Mere when she became the Sparrow to the Falcon. The gods of Naris saw much that they could not believe, understand, or countenance. By the time she learned of this withholding, Mere was past the point of blaming the long dead.

Before the Second and Final Razing of Naris, the Gods-officiant of the Sacred Deeds did not retain the names they bore prior to taking on their new countenances. Because of this Mere never learned the name of her master and predecessor, and she only once saw his face. He was known only by his titles or their variations: the King-errant, Falcon of Naris, God of Messengers. In public she referred to him in those terms or as "this one" or "that one." In private she had called him Da.

The first thing he taught her was that "Veneth is not the only world there is, but it is ours, and that makes it precious." He taught her, as well, that "Veneth blesses the connections made in the hearts of her people. The more these connections, these Associations, are shared in belief among peoples, the stronger and more blessed those Associations become.

"I am the God of Messengers because the people of Naris will for there to be such a god, for that god to be represented by a Whitecrest falcon, and expect for the Falcon to serve after the fashion I do. It is such for all of Naris's gods, and it is such with other nations' peoples and the things they hold in their hearts.

"It is our privilege and our duty to fulfill these stations for the edification of all life on Veneth."

On the surface the Falcon's duties were simple. He was to carry messages and parcels of all kinds across the face of Veneth. But his duty was also to champion and bolster any who sought to serve in the same way regardless of their national allegiance or station in life. As the inhabitant of a position that embodied these ideas, his responsibility to convey urgent messages across great distances with all surety and speed required him to utilize paths that skirted the natural bounds of Veneth.

As his Sparrow, Mere bore witness and learned what was needed for her to take up his godhood when he could no longer inhabit it, and she cherished the work. Yes, she attended to his lessons about the Paradigms, and how one aligns with them. She could dutifully recite them back, and make skillful enough demonstrations of that sacred knowledge. But from the first time the Falcon took the Gilded Sword to a hillside and carved out a door that led them **outside of Veneth**, Mere was enraptured. This, she thought, was the secret uttermost glory of their nation. In the face of the power to walk the roads between realities, what use were other Deeds like the duplication of self or the quieting of the dead?

The years turned the child Sparrow into a young woman. And if over those Mere was not always attentive to the man behind the Falcon's mask, unable to read the face he never exposed to the world, could she really be blamed? She was grateful. She was dutiful. She was brilliant. But she was never permitted to return to the forum she somehow fell into as a child.

When the Falcon came out of one such meeting seeming, perhaps, more haunted and bemused than usual, she thought it likely only the difficulty of politics. She knew that many of the gods desired war and dominion where the Falcon sought service and mutual good. But he would not speak to her while he woke of what he learned from the Butterfly God of Dreams that day, or of the reminders of the things they would not disclose when they bound her as his Sparrow, or of the command he was given that he knew he could not obey. But he would sleep, and sometimes his mutterings would betray whispers of his misgivings to her ears. Despite all the ready answers and mindful care she might give herself in later years, her memories always tried to heft the weight of regret onto her shoulders for not acting on those misgivings.

A month after the Falcon received his troubling instruction, he broke up their routine because, as he claimed, word had reached him that the Marshall's Gate at the edge of the Unkept Wilds was in a state of disrepair. And of course, of all the gates to let fall into disuse, they could not afford to let that one lapse.

As part of the services Naris provided to the rest of Veneth through their God of Messengers the Falcon maintained a set of Gates in certain key locations. Through these Gates the lay people could pass bearing messages, goods, or arms across great distances in the space of a breath. It was essential for the safety of the people (and the goodwill given Naris by the nations that made use of them) that the Gates not malfunction.

One of those Gates had been founded on the border of the Wilds many generations ago for two reasons. The first was that the Wilds were untethered from Place. They roamed or blinked across the continents of Veneth without noticeable pattern. Any nation could find itself a neighbor to the Wilds without warning, and it could last for the span of a day or a decade. The second reason for the Wilds' Gate was that sometimes the Wilds poured forth a dangerous host, be they beasts or phantom forces, and the nations of Veneth needed to be able to field armies to respond in the span of hours or days to protect each other from that standing threat.

Though the Unkept Wilds themselves defy a sense of place, dozens of lesser Places mark the frontiers of the un-mappable, vagrant territory. These border markers adhere to the forms of wells, shelters, and temples which arrive and vanish as apparitions near the real or imagined borders of nations and biomes. These are gathering places for those stricken by experiences in the Wilds. They are also vessels to accumulate the myriad collective Associations that hold the Wilds in a forcibly nebulous state of conceptual wilderness. One such temple usually happened to be near the Wilds' Gate.

The Temple of Answered Questions prefers to manifest in mountain passes, carved into one ancient cliff face or another, noticeable first by the red brick path that leads up to it. At first this path

is haphazard: a brick appears packed into the soil on its lonesome, then a pair, until slowly whatever stone or dirt made up the path before is replaced by a neatly-paved and eventually lacquered little road to the temple's open-arched entryway. It is onto the point where that path transitions into glistening, muted grandeur that the Falcon and his Sparrow emerged.

"Sparrow," he said to Mere, and pointed to a branch in the path that was paved with stones uniformly covered in healthy patches of moss, "that path leads to the Marshall's Gate. Assess its condition. Repair it if you feel it within your abilities. I will be in the temple. There is a message I must deliver this day."

Proud to be trusted with the task on her own, and trusting in turn of her master's intentions, she parted with him there and traveled the path to the Marshall's Gate. The path wound through a small mountain pass and out onto a plateau broad enough for a company of soldiers in closed ranks. The Gate itself was carved into the mountainside, a tall arch whose base had a banded appearance that might have been painted once long ago. As with all of the Marshall's Gates, this one's centerpiece was a stone with a relief in the shape of a sword held vertically with the blade down, as if hanging over the heads of those who would pass through the Gate. A warning, the Falcon had called it. Or a promise.

Some inspection revealed to Mere that the physical arch of the Gate was undamaged. If there was something wrong with the Gate, it was a matter of its Associations. Mere preferred it that way. She was, she must admit, a poor hand at masonry.

The trouble, she determined, was a fairly common one for Gates. Over time, as the Gate was either used or neglected, the local beliefs about the Gate would begin to skew, and this misaligned the careful connection between that Gate and the others in its route. The quickest solution was a matter of discerning which Gates were meant to be on the same route as this Gate, and making a few quick trips along that route to realign the Associations.

She could probably do it herself, but she realized that this particular Marshall's Gate was routed with *all of the other active Gates*. Any nation needed to be able to muster to the Wilds, after all. Yet, Mere wondered, what if something or someone emerged from the Wilds who understood the Gates and their routes instinctively? Couldn't they use this Gate to then launch an attack on any nation on Veneth?

Between the time it would take to pass through every single Gate in a way that would appropriately reinforce this Gate's Associations and her sudden uncertainty about the wisdom of this Gate's existence, Mere decided it was better to bring her assessment to the Falcon than to try to handle it herself. So back up through the pass she went, a pleasant stroll on a pleasant afternoon, until she heard the screaming. Then, of course, Mere ran.

In the Temple of Answered Questions, under the care and ministrations of the God of Messengers, a woman was giving birth. There was only one other person there, a priest of the temple whose demeanor felt out of place to any nation Mere had visited with the Falcon. Together, Mere and the two men saw to the woman's needs as best they could. The labor was agony for the woman. It was enough to convince Mere that she had no interest in going through such an ordeal for herself.

But as the labor wore on, the tenor of the situation changed. A fervor came over the priest and the mother. The cries of pain and effort turned to ones of rapture. And the Falcon? Who could read his face beneath that mask? It seemed his eyes were like that of a raptor's: piercing, impassive. Even as he worked to aid the mother, his manner became terse.

Eventually, even Mere felt it coming, like the temple itself groaned with the pangs of this childbirth. The sky darkened, turning her attention away from the labor. Mere moved to the

entrance of the temple to watch Heaven split itself with lightnings. In the midst of the birth, the Wilds grew restless, pacing across the face of Veneth like a father too unnerved to provide support for the arrival of the thing he has helped to create. Mere saw vistas of Kolomaer, Qastra, and Naris pass by to the rhythm of the mother pushing. She saw lands even the Falcon had not delivered a message to in living memory. And her own organs felt like they were twisting inside her, trying to turn her attention on the impending birth like her body was a plant seeking the sun.

She feared to turn and bear witness, then, until the Falcon placed a hand on her shoulder.

“Is this why we came?” she asked.

Before the Falcon answered, Veneth did. The Wilds perched the Temple on a fjord overlooking the interminable storm on the Sea of Goletha just in time for an enormous thunder-swell to drive them bodily back from the temple entrance. When the roaring of the thunder died, they could hear the baby crying.

The Falcon turned, and as if the words were ripped from his mouth, declared, “Behold! A child is born tonight in the hall of answers! He will tame the waters of Goletha. He will marshall all Veneth to his name. He will bear witness to the coming ruin. Rejoice, for his aim is peace! Weep, for he clothes himself in glory! Behold, Thrast! The gods welcome you!”

And Mere, watching this declaration with the storm now raging in her stomach, stared at the Falcon’s trembling hand that held the Gilded Sword. His grip was always so sure and steady. Not now. There was a slow, incredulous plunge, punctuated by the tiny cries of that little child placed on his mother’s breast, as the Falcon approached with all the grace and doom of a swooping bird of prey. Mere watched, frozen, until at long last her master reached out and cut the cord that tied Thrast to his mother’s womb with a sword that could carve doorways between realms.

Then the Falcon staggered out past Mere into the storm-winds.

A Soul For the Kiln

What weight has a gaze
 Measured, the impulse of resolution
 Choices you're driven to make
 When you triangulated their attention
 And it was on you



Lila has returned to the Adamson house from the city many times, whether from shopping and hanging out with friends in the latter days of high school or visiting the family on holidays and weekends throughout most of her undergrad. The landscape of rural southwest Michigan is peppered with modern ruins: abandoned barns and crumbling homes that are neighbors to the bespoke and newly constructed with brand new pickup trucks in their driveways. Time and vegetation will slowly drag evidence of human neglect beneath the soil. This has been the state of the world as she sees it. It is a system where entropy's promised end is being helped along by greed and self-possession. But now, apparently, it's worse than that. Because now, apparently, there's a monster in her family's home.

Screaming down the road at the pace of the hurlant rhapsody of guitar riffs and dark crashes playing from her speakers doesn't deflect or soften the blows these vistas strike, though. They hit her just as hard and they hit her faster. She doesn't shed tears on the drive, but by the time she reaches her parents' driveway her knuckles are aching.

Lila tries calling David four more times on the way. Every time she calls the automated voice says that his number is unavailable. Each time she feels a twinge of dread between her lower ribs and then a further, fuzzier answering pang like the toll of a distant bell or a tug on a thread. Something has gone sour with reality, she thinks, but her last thought as she tears to a stop and tumbles out of her car is that there might also be something off with *her*.

The house is quiet from the outside, but it's big and well-insulated, so even if something is happening inside she might not be able to hear unless she gets closer. She hesitates when she notices the quiet. It's a chance, just a breath, to try to gather herself and to see if she can spot anything amiss on the property. In that hanging moment, part of her hopes she'll see David come running through that door, that it's all some strange prank he pulled on her. Even for just a moment, the thought that her parents might be the ones to show up appeals to her too. But the house is still, looming over her like a calm adult assessing the panicked breathing of a child underfoot.

She considers her approach. She could drift into the yard between the two embattled maples to peer through the kitchen window, but that would give her away. If she slips in through the garage she can collect some improvised weapons on the way in. Or there's the window in the back that she can climb through.

It would make the decision easier to know what she should take “he will unmake you” to mean. The warning the grim stranger gave on David’s call was unsurprisingly dire, but also the word used to describe what she would find here was “man.” The thing about men that are monsters is that they are still flesh and blood. All flesh unmakes easily enough.

Lila settles on snatching up a pair of pruning shears and her dad’s driver out of the garage and heading to the back. There’s a little low shed right behind the house, close enough that she easily hauls herself and her weapons onto its roof and from there grasps the sill of her brother’s window. David doesn’t keep it locked; he likes having an out.

It catches her off guard to be disappointed that David’s room is empty. The blankets are thrown back near the foot of his bed, and the sheets are laden with two open notebooks, a bookmarked novel, and his laptop, which is open and displaying the question, “Are you still watching?” Clothes litter the floor. His typical mess. The neatest part of his room is the short bookshelf in the corner. He’s squeezed as much space as he can out of the shelf, ordering novels by author and series, with fantasy taking up most of the territory. Last year’s copy of *The Great American Short Story* is sitting on top. It has three more bookmarks tagging certain stories within. David’s white door is closed as always.

As Lila takes this in she hears a quiet sucking sound coming from what she thinks is the kitchen. At first hearing it only makes her freeze. But as she listens closer, the sounds of wet toil flip her guts like an omelette. Goosebumps roll down her arms. She grips the driver in both hands, then waits. The source of the sound doesn’t seem to be coming closer.

She tries to re-center.

The corner of an empty picture frame peeks out from behind David’s dresser. It’s the one she gave him a couple birthdays ago along with a print of one of the sloppiest and most endearing pictures of Giddy she could find. He was supposed to put it up in his room and look at it to remember the love that one good dog had given them all. There’s no print to be seen. Just the dark frame. Is that a crack in the glass?

He keeps claiming there’s nothing wrong. He said it was stupid. That he’s somewhere else already.

A flush of heat drives her out into the hall.

Once the door opens, the crash of glass jars and thunks of boxes run together with stretching rubber and starch-thickened water circling a drain. Sulfur in the nose. Salt on the tongue. It’s coming from the kitchen, just a few steps down the hall. She approaches driver-first.

There she finds the contents of the kitchen rearranging themselves into the shape of a man. In nature flesh forms itself with decorum: the resources a being gathers are tucked behind a veil, worked on behind the scenes until the fruits of that labor are ready to be presented. This... isn’t that--this isn’t flesh yet. It’s not a man yet. Water from the running faucet falls into an eddy of rapidly corporating material; eggs boiling together with pop-tarts, a pork-chop, leftover stir fry vegetables still partially in their container, and a tub of ice cream are all still barely recognizable amidst cording musculature, calcifying bone, and congealing soft tissues.

As Lila stumbles upon someone flaying himself into *being* in her parents’ kitchen, she feels the transgression like a knife in her chest. There’s a weight to the presence she has just entered. When she steps into the room, the would-be flesh mass shifts. It has only formed a shape of something that resembles a head yet, but that elliptical orb filled with olives and jewelry turns slightly, and *his attention* settles on her.

Lila yelps. Her joints lock in place.

Ah, a voice that is not her own interjects into her thoughts. He sounds as if he has found the line he was thumbing for in a book. The interjection is accompanied by another punch of that knife in her chest. She feels the heat of it, tries to look down but only her eyes move, and just long enough to see that there's no actual wound.

The voice says, *I had wondered if minds here would be as pliant*. His tone is, again, conversational, but it buzzes like an intrusive thought, demanding her attention and creasing her forehead. *Do please try to suppress your alarm. I shall be as gentle as I can, but you should know that those weapons are to no avail.*

Her body will not move. It won't respond to her at all. She aches to take a breath that won't come. Her eyes burn. Her diaphragm tries to lurch, halts, cramps. Meanwhile the shape coheres in front of her, though her vision swims and flickers.

Moments of blessed silence. Thoughts flare and race through her mind like meteors across a night sky. She can't track them, can't keep hold of them, except that it's *him*. He is doing this to her. Casually! Carelessly! The silence is snatched away.

You must understand my caution. You are not one of those who destroyed my body and cast me out, yet report of it echoes in your thoughts. How could that have been? My first discovery was that this place has somehow laid dormant to the Paradigms for all of its history, until some errant thread tied me to that other.

Your brother, it seems? And by some fluke he passed on just enough to warn you of my coming. Now here you are, ready to brain me for a home-invading thug. Oh, Lila Adamson, my spectacularly helpless creature. I see it nascent in you. That glint in your eyes. You will bind yourself to these affairs. You will mire yourself in the wet clay of this world as I remake it.

He releases her breath, which comes to her in coughing gasps that rattle in her throat.

In the time that has passed, he has managed to approximate enough organs to enable speech, because the next words come from his mouth and not within her own mind.

"So many questions you're drowning under that formless rage," he says. "It is best to let these things go. There is work to be done." A sort of eye has forms, briefly, from a piece of amber shaped to appear as a star. He uses this to eye her appraisingly.

Lila's breathing has grated into a wordless growl. All he will allow.

He says, "Yet it seems it is the nature of the yoked to buck against the man who drives the plow."

Because her jaw is locked half-open, she screams in her head, *We are not livestock!*

"And I do not preside over beasts. Lila, your mind quivers. Your will howls itself ragged in the valley of your impotence. It will not remain this way. You will learn to serve your purpose without complaint. But you have limits, and those force me to relent. You will be of less use to me dead. So I must see for myself the state of my newest inheritance if I am to rectify its faults and prevent the Ruin you would bring it to."

Drifting above the linoleum with feet that are still forming, he passes by Lila with an effortless indifference. The front door of the Adamson house opens unbidden for him. He makes a show of turning again. The star-eye has been replaced by one much more organic, but also bloodshot. He says, "Stay."

Then he is gone.

He left the faucet running.

Hyperventilating. Mental static. A thunderstorm heartbeat in a body pinned into place. Lila screams. She can see nothing. She can hear nothing but her own shredding voice. A tiny silver thread whispers, “You’re in shock.” And an amber one, filled with the calm of resignation, tries to tell her to be relieved that he’ll be coming back to turn the faucet off.

It’s still there, that initial transgression from meeting him. That was all it took to give her *this*. One abrupt introduction to a new reality. He seized control of her in that moment of realization, using a power from beyond Earth. What did he say? “Dormant to the Paradigms?” But it’s not sleeping anymore. Magic unfurls itself in Lila like the blossoming fire of a wound to the chest, and the magic is the irreducible assignation of meaning.

This is Association.

She doesn’t belong to Thrast. She is her own, but to reclaim the use of her own body against what he imposed on her, she needs more than just the Association kindled in her heart. It took Thrast more than just that to assert himself over her. It took reaching out. She can feel it, like taut threads reaching straight through the walls of the Adamson house towards where Thrast went. It’s within her, too, in the way she counts the seconds since he left, and countless lines of thought streaming across the night sky of her mind trying to plan or reason or dream her way out of this trap. Magic unfurls itself in her like the blossoming fire of a wound to the chest, and it is the scroll-the-job-listings, nervous-cover-letter glance you steal before you take a dive.

This is Extension.

With it Lila reaches through the extent of her own body, and iron laces her nerves and joints. This one has always been there waiting for her, the constant self-declarative “Mine,” the possessive shriek that tore from her voice when her own self-authority was undermined. It’s been surging toward the surface, looking for the touch of intent and meaning to release it. Magic unfurls itself in her like the blossoming fire of a wound to the chest, and it is ownership, even of pain.

This is Domination.

Lila unlocks her self. She staggers over to the sink, with that water still running, and deposits the contents of her stomach down the drain. She allows herself precious time to be wracked with sobbing, to scream and swear and curl into a ball. Then she rolls back to her feet, aching, and turns it all to cold fury. Thrast has been gone for no more than two minutes.

Lila leaves the faucet running. She bursts out the still-open front door and sprints to her car in the driveway.

Her suitcase in the trunk has enough clothes for a weekend of unpredictable Michigan weather, including a navy-colored scarf she knitted for herself and her favorite jacket, once a deep and dark red but faded from years of constant use. She wraps the scarf around her neck, despite how hot her chest feels, but doesn’t put that jacket on yet.

Her body is still screaming in pain, covered over in cramps from being locked in place. When you’ve chosen a path—when you’ve started down it, the travel itself wears you down. You rest, you eat, you turn that time and energy into new strength. You use every breath to displace the exhaustion of your cells and bolster them in defiance of entropy. And when you decide you’re going to take your fragile little body to the moon, you build yourself a damn rocket. Magic unfurls itself in Lila like the blossoming fire of a wound to the chest, and it’s the closing of the wound.

This is Edification.

Lila looks to the sky, where the taut threads of Thrast's Extension still point her. He won't be gone long. He left the faucet running, and it's possible he may have noticed at this point. Her window is vanishingly small. She doesn't have time to question herself. Sometimes you just have to commit to closing a door. Magic unfurls itself in Lila like the blossoming fire of a wound to the chest, and it is the parting both of the teeth from the flesh and the flesh from itself.

This is Separation.

With these Paradigms, especially with this last one, she can find a loose thread in Thrast and unravel him before he can do more of what he just did to her to the world. But first, to hijack the power of a tyrant.

Lila makes her own threads of Extension, reaching out to four objects and into herself. She climbs into the driver's seat of her car. Her chosen vessels Associate to her the way a loved one is awakened by a soft touch. They become a part of her.

There are five.

Into the Oakley ring, which has passed through four generations of her family, she pours her Spirit, the essence of her emotions and connections with the world around her. A garnet, sardonyx, sapphire, and amethyst form the petals of a flower around an empty setting. The unending storm of experiences remembered, interpreted, and expected resides within Association, and through it she will assign meaning to the things she experiences. As Lila pushes her Association into the ring the empty setting is filled with a gleaming mote of fire.

And her Mind, a scramble of thought and parsed information projected into the intent of action, shunts into a smartphone wreathed in a black leather case. It is an ancillary to each other vessel: it's not the judge but the paralegal; it is the axle not the steering wheel; it's the statue in the mind of the sculptor; it is that which takes the measure of a divide. With her mind, she directs (but does not control) every part of herself, and from within a device that has a transceiver she can Extend herself to probe the whole of the world, if need be. While her mind's new casing does not visibly change, its programming is irretrievably rewritten.

Her body retains her Domination. Her will, which her ring generates and her phone conducts, shall be executed by her body. Lila takes a breath. She releases it.

Into her scarf she places the stuff of her vitality, the impulse of genesis present in all cells that still divide. Edification will drive her to rebuild herself and raise up both substance and structure in the world around her. Her other vessels are vectors, but Vita will be her source and her destination. She wears the scarf as the mantle of her chosen duty, to live and to support life. Its hem un-knits itself and the threads start to weave into her hair and through her shirt.

Her jacket becomes the Edge of her being, a Separation between what is Lila and what is not. It is the most essential of tools: a knife, shield, hatchet, or veil as she requires. It sits around her shoulders and takes on a strangely heavy weight.

For a moment she lingers like this, her existence divvied between five objects but still whole. The vessels carry a tension. If she releases the pressure she will bounce back into herself. It will not last on its own. There has to be a line drawn she cannot cross again. The part of her that would hesitate, that would dwell on this snap decision and weigh its ramifications, is caught up still counting seconds till Thrast's likely return. If she is caught in the midst, she will never get the chance again. If she fails to seize this opportunity now, while Thrast is still getting his bearings, no one on Earth will be safe from his will. So she acts.

Shifting, she slides her arms through the sleeves of her jacket and shimmies it on. A symbolic gesture, Associated instinctively with the act it accompanies: tying off each of the five vessels from the others, and snipping their connections.

Her ring flares. Her phone chirps. Her body stiffens. Her thread crawls down her arms. Then her breath escapes her lungs and her hand drops to the seat of the car, where skin and upholstery simultaneously ignite.



Thrust
 Meanwhile 

Thrust ascends past a commingled canopy and into the open air. From the Lower Sky he looks out at the landscape nearby. There are many buildings, built to stand apart from each other, each with their own small field of tailored grass and even smaller aesthetic gardens. Some even have fences erected between their own plots. But each house is also connected to the others, not just by roadways but by wires that hang from poles and lattice whole communities.

He climbs higher, into the Upper Sky, and spreads his Extension farther. The tang he first sensed in the air is a corruption. It is unseasonably hot. In the distance, there are smoke-clouds in the sky from the fires of industry. Each adult seems to have a personal carriage that functions by burning a particularly flammable elixir. In one place he spots a tremendous set of rolling hills of detritus, of scrap metal and the strange substance Lila named in her mind as plastic. Fields of waste, un-cared for. He finds a city of great towers mid-construction. It is swarming with people. Those that do not suffer outwardly seem to have glaring holes in their souls. They stuff this full of whatever is at hand.

“Is this what we do to ourselves,” Thrust asks himself as he hangs in the Upper Sky, “wherever we are?” As with the people of Veneth, the tide of their mistakes is coming in and they are not watching the horizon. The wind sighs around Thrust, a long deep bellow of resignation from deeply-buried hopes. “Nor will I allow this candle to snuff itself.”

He returns to the girl.

Faced with Doubt, Finality Blinks



If the Bridge were an actual physical object in a place where physicality was properly embodied and expressed to the mind by ordinary means, then the Bridge's relationship to the Sword would need to be communicated with details that can be grasped, like the apparent relative ages of the stone and the steel and a webbing of cracks that communicate the effects of the passage of time on both. But while this realm is old and the Sword is older still, there are no signs of weathering. The Sword's apparent position in the Bridge is only a signpost of the effect the Sword has had on the Bridge. The Sword is not even bound to this realm.

David will process this later. Right now he can't see past the spectacle of the Sword, though he can almost see a figure of light, posed like it's holding the sword in place. The figure's attention arrests him on sight. That central tether strains against David's imagined mass. The last outward thing he notices is Mustang clapping his second hand on David's other shoulder like he's trying to keep David from losing his balance. Maybe he is.

"WHO APPROACHES ME?" A stray thought passes through David's mind on encountering the angel's voice: why would someone with a voice so commanding resort to the vulnerability of asking a question?

Then when Mere and Mustang are conspicuously, agonizingly silent, David feels put on the spot. When he tries to look to them, he can't make out their faces in the glare of the angel's light and the flames of the Sword.

He answers, "*It's David.*"

"WHY HAS DAVID HUXLEY ADAMSON COME TO STAND BEFORE MY VIGIL?" Mere'd *just* told him that they'd arrive when the thought that carried them here was completed. She also said...

"*We're here to talk to Lenn,*" David says. It's his best guess, but the angel doesn't seem to accept the answer.

The angel leans forward, faceless gaze weighing David.

Having taken its measurements, the angel asks, "DO YOU KNOW WHAT WAITS BEYOND MY VIGIL?"

David makes a fidgety gesture at the giant sword that's on fire and emanating waves of biblical finality. He tries to say, "I'm gonna guess an Eden." But it comes out "*AN END.*"

What? That's not what he meant. He tries to correct himself. "*An end. An end? An end! An... end. An end...*" By then his face feels hot. There is a buzzing cloud of insects in his mind. Fur under his fingers, him raking in tight breaths, looking into a dog's face and trying to say good-bye.

"WHY DO YOU FEAR DEATH?"

What the hell kind of question is that for an angel to be asking him *now*? Didn't they bring him here with the unspoken understanding he was going to die? If he wasn't ready to do that for the people of Earth, or even just for his sister and his parents, then why would he have come? If this is what it takes to fix it, then what other choice does he have?

So why ask him if he's afraid? You don't guide a lamb to the slaughter and then stop with the knife in your hand and say, "Are you sure you want to do this?" You don't want them stuck there anticipating, soaking in the immensity of the realization that this is what your life has amounted to. You surprise the lamb. Make it quick and painless. Kind if you can manage it.

Of course the frightening thing is the clarity. All the buzzing turmoil has been pushed into the distance of his mind. In its place is the vision of the angel, like someone forced to visualize the feeling of having a gaze on you without being allowed to use the symbolism of an eye. A humanoid figure that itself contracts to focus in on you.

The angel is doing something to him. It isn't even subtle. It's Abraham on a hilltop, tying his son to an altar while the kid's asking him what's happening. There is clear ritual to the questions the angel is asking him, to the way David's being responds almost on its own to them. And yes of course David's afraid to die. The reasons he might be afraid are so obvious. It's *death*. But the question hits deeper, slides along that spike in his center and seeps into the cracks in the pillar of his being, posing some other, harsher question to him. And he can't answer it. Anything pithy dies in his throat (double-metaphor, since breathing doesn't even exist here). Anything earnest falls short of coalescing into words. David likes to think his will is strong, that he can make himself do what he knows is right regardless how the rest of his being revolts.

As he stands there paralyzed, struggling to find a way to answer, dreading the moment he does, the briefest shadow seems to pass over the angel and the Sword. Mustang's voice cuts through the crushing silence at the End of the Bridge, and David returns to himself.



Mere		
	Meanwhile	

Just as Mere feared, Lenn is not waiting at the end of the Bridge to meet them.

Mere suffers when she approaches the end of the Bridge. She concedes that the thing at the end could be a Sword in some higher sense, but the thing is too brilliant and terrible to risk giving her full attention. It's shrouded in light, and the weight of that shroud seems in turns to be either the evening glory that fell on the marbled walls of Naris in her childhood or the blaze that toppled them while she was truant. It may not show the same face to everyone who approaches, but Mere's impression is that in the presence of the Sword one finds that the Now becomes staked through the blasted remains of that palace, Memory, and the humors that expel from Memory's wounds in turn paint a frantic sunset of gilded loss. The figure of the angel, just a ghost in Mere's periphery, still portends enough posture to lend the sense that this time it is not distracted by the demands of Lenn's presence². It seems to watch her with the wary and sad regard of a healer at the bedside of the surely doomed.

Because of the monument of dread this raises in her, Mere avoids coming to the end of the Bridge alone out of outright necessity. She would not come at all if the obligations of her office did not demand it. Were she to venture here of her own accord, with no others' affairs to attend, would she find herself caught in the grasp of questions voiced by an angel? Now is difficult enough, given that the nature of this visit and some outside influence have conspired to render the rest of the Bridge as an unbounded eternity stuffed with fathomless volumes of ash. It's created an almost unbearable contrast: the ceaseless tangle of the dark against the unyielding light of a promised end.

For fear of inviting the angel to address her, she dares not dwell on questions about why this place has manifested this way to her, but Mere cannot keep the questions out of her own heart, so she permits some she hopes will do less harm in the moment. What does Persaval see here? How does the Sword tease the longings and regrets of that poor man's heart? Especially with the Circle's

²or the embrace of a tired Falcon.

bonds scattered, any insight into that question is closed to her. Still his tension tightens his moments as they draw ever closer to the grandeur of Finality.

And what of this boy David, whom she marches across a Bridge towards what can only be considered his death? Is this truly the path wrought for him? And does she have a choice? She is a Falcon again, but this time more like a nesting mother who bears a still-wriggling mouse in her talons to offer up its life for the survival of her charges.

A familiar whisper³ tells her that this is what she was promised. She was always meant to inherit—commit—embody this horror. Mere rebukes that voice, rubbing a finger along the Iron Ring on her left index, but it cannot be silenced. It is sealed away, no direct danger to Veneth or the Bridge, but a fragment of it still worms its way through her soul. She had hoped that maybe by some good fortune she could banish it more thoroughly once they succeeded in cursing Thrast, but even he is not truly gone yet. The whisper of that hungry distant realm uses the tenor and cadence of her own voice. It assures her that she should never fear to lose its companionship.

The boy, Mere insists to herself. How is this affecting the boy? She turns to regard him.

David is frozen in place, eyes large to take in the sight of a flaming Sword the size of a building plunged into the stonework of the Bridge. His expression is slacked, as if his attention has drifted elsewhere even as he faces the end. Both of Persaval's hands are on the boy's shoulders now, an attempt by the Arbiter to guide or assure or forestall some fomenting danger, or some combination of all of those things.

"It's David," the boy says.

Persaval looks Mere in the eyes. He looks to the End.

Mere's hackles rise.

With a tone like he is answering a question Mere did not hear, David says, "We're here to talk to Lenn."

Persaval pulls David back a step up the Bridge. He asks where his husband is. The boy doesn't seem to notice either of these things.

Mere says, "He did not remain here."

Persaval's eyes flick from the End to Mere again. "We should also be gone."

David says, "An end." His eyes widen further, startled at the words that escaped him. He speaks again, quickly, and increasingly distraught, "An end. An end? An end! An... end. An end..." Persaval tries to drag David back another step, but the boy digs his feet in and somehow, despite straining with effort, Persaval cannot get him to budge.

He asks, "Is this why you really brought him here? To offer him up?"

Mere feels her own body stiffening. "Questions are dangerous here, Sworn Sword. Here, of all places, the Question begs an answer."

"Answer me, Mere."

She studies the boy's face. Can he hear them while the angel burns its Questions? Maybe not.

She says, "To rid us of Thrast, David must take the departure offered here and carry Thrast with him beyond."

"Oh?" Persaval's protective grip on David tightens.

³: honeyed, ashen

“Can’t you feel it?” Mere hears herself say. “The pressure. Can you smell the musk of Thrast on him? Does it not convict you?”

“You said questions are dangerous,” Persaval observes. “Where is my husband, Mere?”

“I cannot know without searching.”

Persaval says, “I cannot do it thus.” His eyes fall on the boy. Some hidden reserve within him coils and strikes. He asks, “David, can you hear me?”

As if startled awake, the boy turns his head. “What?”

Something releases for Mere as well, but she feels the attention of the angel turning toward her again. She says, “I may have been mistaken. Lenn is not here, and that raises questions about the path ahead. Arrows drawn in sand, David. I must regather our bonds. While I do, none should remain here at the End.”

Whatever grave but brief misalignment took her before has righted itself. She turns her head and wills up a doorway back to what should be a safe region on Veneth. The door is of sturdy reddish oak, and blessedly it conjures with it a slice of overcast sky. Even that glimpse of gray, melancholic cloudscape brings a flare of relief from the oppressive emptiness that had surrounded them. She guides them to the doorway, opens it with the Gilded Sword, then hurries toward her own passage as they escape the black.

Hers is not a door at all. Instead it is the entrance to a hollow on a wintry mountainside. She welcomes the bracing cold, the stinging wet of a blast of snowy air that tries to fend her off, as she plunges through and escapes the eyeless gaze of the End that awaits her.

She hopes that Persaval is right, and that they have not just thrown away their last chance at sparing Veneth from Thrast’s attentions.

Truth in Five Words Eminent

Persaval

Erstwhile

The homestead Persaval and his husband Lenn had made together sat atop a raised plot of ground in the middle of a plain like an island amidst a sea of grass. It bathed often in golden sunlight. A small wood stood not far to the west, dwarfed by the Great River that had long ago named first a settlement, then a city, and eventually a nation. There was a taste to the wind here, a little sage sweetness. Here in Ea'river they called it "amber on the wind," claiming that the sun had gilded the winds over the generations the way it had gilded the nation's sacred History Stones. Persaval stood within their home, breathing deeply of the amber-breeze, and contently prepared the vegetables for their evening meal.

The cabin itself was small, humble by design. It had a single room, with a stove and counter in one corner, a bed in another, and a little lacquered table that stood a few inches off the floor in the center. Their storehouse was actually bigger. If you knew what you sought you could spot its low stone arch from the doorway. Below were their food stores, weapons, and other needed supplies. That left the cabin to be the warm embrace that it was: sanded wood and river stone; shelves bore fired-clay cups and bowls above the counter; more shelves just above head height held selected facets of amber in careful settings. Here, Persaval and Lenn had situated a peace that had been carefully built and then blissfully maintained.

Elsewhere's turbulence didn't reach here.

"Here's a conversation worth having," Lenn said as he brought in a wrap of cutlets from their storehouse. There was still blood on the cloth, so this must have been from a recent kill. Persaval sensed that Lenn was carrying something else in with the meat, a faint burn of Association that he would not have noticed if it wasn't from his husband. Was this something Lenn had been dwelling on while out hunting? Longer than that? Lenn kept on, as always implacably in-the-moment. He reached out to shake the bowl of vegetables Persaval had been filling. The slices settled, leaving Persaval more room to work. Lenn didn't need to confirm that he had Persaval's attention. When didn't he have it? "What do the Wilds mean?"

Persaval set out one last root, spun, and lit their stove by flicking out a spark of his aura, temporarily held separate and sustained by walls of Separation, to flicker into a flame that could only radiate heat up onto the surface of the pan above it as he directed. It was a practiced application of his Paradigms, rote after years learning to harness what the paths of reality afforded him, but there was something in the rhythm of Lenn's entrance, in the Association he'd brought inside, that made Persaval take note of the particulars of the moment. He did so with something not quite reaching concern. This was unusual, but it didn't feel like it was misaligned to the aura of warmth they had cultivated in this place, **their** place.

While he took note of this, Persaval asked, "The Wilds?"

Lenn unwrapped the cuts of meat and tumbled them into the pan in perfect rhythm. He said, "Without them, life would seem almost too neat. We would have the near-perfect illusion of control, could expect that life will persist the way we've imagined it will. But the Wilds won't let us forget that all of our boundaries are lines drawn on a shore, and the Wilds are the tide."

As Lenn finished saying this, Persaval stepped close to add the finished vegetables to the meat in the pan. He snatched a pinch of herb and spice to dash on all of it. Then he wrapped an arm around Lenn.

Persaval said, "Some direction, oh artful Questioner? Is this topic political or paradigmatic at heart?"

Lenn leaned into him. Warmth. He said, "This conversation is about structure."

Persaval peeled his eyes from Lenn's and turned some of his attention to stirring the frying ingredients of their dinner. Invisible divisions manifested in the pan, new barriers that conformed to the shape of the pan while pushing and turning vegetables and cutlets of venison to keep everything cooking evenly but not burning. He could use Separation to slice straight through the pan if that was what he wanted, but why would he want to? "In what way is this about structure? That it is fleeting? Tenuous?"

Lenn watched the pan stir itself. His fingers traced unseen lines up Persaval's arm. "That it's limited by definition. We see for ourselves how forces often move outside those limits in ways beyond our ken." He paused to snatch up a cutlet of venison that had scarcely taken on a sear. He popped it into his mouth, smiling softly around it as he chewed. "They are **indifferent** to our limits."

"So Veneth is a pan of stir fry."

Lenn shrugged.

"Structure is meaningless, then?" A question compelled by the line of Lenn's argument. Persaval thought he could see where Lenn was going with this, but he preferred to hear it in his husband's words. Everyone else was so careful how they spoke around the infamous champion of the Game of Questions, lest they be manipulated by a master of Domination into a realignment of their entire existence. They missed so much, fearing that result. So much of Lenn's personality was genuine invitation, and so much of his perspective was shaped by being aligned with a Paradigm like Domination. That had to be a mighty weight. Knowing that, Persaval counted it a joy to let Lenn be himself.

And Lenn proceeded to. "Count your words, my husband." Four. Lenn stepped away from the pan, but gave Persaval's arm a squeeze as he pulled free. He set a couple smaller bowls at their table on the floor. "Rituals: When we take five words to say a thing, the thing we've said resounds with truth. Why? Because there are five Paradigms? Just by chance? Why does a Game of Questions work the way it does to skew the scales of power? Why do the lanterns of the Gentlefishers calm the storm around their ships? There are always new and surprising rules to discover about how the world works. Are they rules because we found them and called them rules? Did we weave them into existence, or are they immutable truths? Anyone can purposefully break the rule of the Truth In Five Words Eminent just by knowing it exists and deciding to be contrary. Does that make it useless to observe the ritual?"

Persaval looked up from the pan. He gave Lenn a long, quiet smile. "It's ready." He snuffed out the flame on the stove as easily as Lenn had plucked out the bite of meat: he dropped the barriers of Separation that held the flake of his aura in place and it drifted back into his soul like a scattered ember that cooled and fell back into the fire.

"Look at that," Lenn said, grinning as he gingerly moved the pan to their table on the floor. "I can smell the resherb."

Persaval cocked his head at his husband. "You haven't reached your point," he said. But he settled down cross-legged across from Lenn, nostrils full of the scent of their dinner.

"My point," Lenn said, using a spoon to dole out some stir fry into the bowls for the two of them, "is that the purpose of structure, of ritual, law, or recipe, is not to set One True Definition of Reality, or to know and control something just to **have control**. It's to make a meal."



That big red door is gone the moment Mustang follows David through. It's only then that he releases David's shoulder and even then after letting David stagger forward and savor the sensation of breathing again, the guy's protective posture doesn't seem to drop.

They're standing on the stones of some sort of overgrown courtyard which is slowly being swallowed by weeds, moss, wildflowers, and the layers of soil the plants sprang from and became. It was huge, once. Parking lot-sized. The bricks of the courtyard themselves are the size of small parking spaces. Behind where David and Persaval came out there's a half-collapsed arch that would have cast its shadow across them if the sky wasn't so gloomy. The stones of that arch catch David's attention, because there are symbols across the face of the portion that's still standing and also carved into the stones around the base of it. The courtyard ends at that arch, so that the hook shape of the broken arch frames a few miles of unbroken tall grass.

Even though half the arch is spilled out into that grass, the crown of the arch somehow stands free. That central stone's carving is of a sword with the tip pointed down, ready to plunge straight through the symbol on the stone of the courtyard directly beneath it. Seeing that, David feels his anchor-line pull tight like it had on the Bridge, and it comes with an imagined blast of heat and the feeling of being watched.

Buzzing. Panic.

A gust and the scent it carries pulls him out of it. Off to what he guesses is the North there's an ocean that devoured the horizon a long time ago, but the horizon must have given it indigestion. A dozen dark gray stormclouds are stacking themselves into a tower out over that ocean, halfway towards the horizon. Lightning cracks within the growing storm, and the thunder that follows is distant but still rattles his chest. The way the storm has gathered, blocking a view of the horizon, feels in the moment like watching a bear standing up to loom over a kill.

"The Sea of Goletha," Mustang says. "There is always a storm on its waters."

David slips his phone from his pocket and records a video. He checks for notifications and service while he does it. Nothing. But the battery life indicator is missing. He feels... blank. It raises the itch to fish out his earbuds and play some music, but—

"Can I have my ear bud back?" he asks.

Mustang pulls from a pocket and opens his hand. Such a look races across his face that David is surprised the guy doesn't drop what he's holding like a live coal. Well, given he regularly sets his sword on fire, maybe this is exactly how he would react to a live coal.

For a moment, David glimpses what's surprised Officer Firesword: instead of a little headphone-what-you-put-in-your-ear, there's a tiny chunk of amber. Then the moment passes and it resolves into the object it's supposed to be. David plucks the earbud out of Mustang's hand.

He surprises himself by tucking it into its case with its twin. Then he says, "It's clear that we're both back-footed here. Do we have time to unpack, or are you gonna rush me off to another trauma event?"

Mustang continues to stare at his hand. "All I require is you stay close." It's muttered, distracted.

With the sense of urgency deflated, it's hard to think of what to ask first. Harder still because that anchor-line still hasn't given him any slack. *It's still coming*. Delayed, even? His phone is still in his hand. The screen goes black as he glances at it. He wakes it up. Goes to his texts. Him noting to Dad that they were out of pickles and Dad being a Dad about it, typing out "thumbs up emoji" just to try to get a rise out of him. Mark trying to get him a job. Lila's one-word response to a rant he'd sent her about how a book ended.

Finally, he finds the angle his brain will let him start from. "What was the point of that? Playing chicken with an angel, dragging me right up to a Big Knife and then saying 'never mind?'"

Mustang pauses (maybe put off by an idiom that didn't translate) and slowly lowers his hand before saying, "How much did you hear of what Mere and I said to each other?"

"She just said that you guys might have gotten off-course. But you were so close. How do you know you haven't missed our chance?"

"We spoke while you answered," Mustang said. He said it like he was choosing his words. Counting them. And somehow, David believed him. "You didn't hear me challenge her near the End, but you heard me in the tower. I was reckless the first time I tried to be rid of Thrast, and I cut my own heart out instead. I shan't repeat that mistake."

"But it's gonna mean me dead, isn't it?" David asked. "One way or another?"

"We do not know that."

"But probably."

Mustang asks, "Is that what you want?"

David feels the sensation of the angel studying him again. Feels the burning, the buzzing like static, feels his mind turning away to something else.

"So what's up with that broken gate?"

Mustang regards it. His hand drifts to his side.

He says, "It is a Marshall's Gate. A relic. I suppose it was easier for Mere to send us through here, but I had not thought it possible to come and go from Veneth herself by such a gate."

"How is that still hanging there?"

"The stone is crumbling, but some Associations must be holding it together." Mustang takes one step closer, eyes scanning the structure, and then gestures them both back. "These gates are more dangerous than I knew. There is no telling where it might send you if you crossed that threshold now. Across realms? Into the harrowing Wilds? Mere has kept her peace about them for too long."

"You're saying that she was lying about them?"

"She rarely reveals knowledge from the days before her homeland became a desolation."

David opens a notes app and swipes in some key words to remember.

- ***Veneth.***
- ***Marshall's Gate.***
- ***Mere's desolate homeland.***
- ***Thrast.***

He says, "You called the Gate a relic. How long ago are we placing that desolation?"

"Centuries ago," Mustang says.

“So Mere is, like, closer to 500 years old than to 40?”

“I don’t know. Lenn and Mere say that different realms treat the passage of time differently, especially liminal ones like the Bridge. Mere mentioned something of this as we approached the End.”

David adds *Time is unreliable* to his notes.

Mustang watches him swipe. “You are fond of this miniature slate?”

“Helps to write some things down,” David says, “When I can’t keep it straight in my head.”

“A writing surface, a link to the voices of your loved ones, and a record-taker. Seems a useful tool.”

“Shame it took applying generations of accumulated scientific discovery and a system chaining millions of people to the profit motive to achieve it. And what does it get me now? I can’t call my sister back across the multiverse. Just take some videos no one else will ever see and some notes. I’m not even sure how it’s still working. It’s supposed to connect to a giant network of similar machines using invisible light waves back on Earth. There’s none of that here. And it’s supposed to be powered by a battery, a little tool inside the machine that stores power as chemical energy and doles it out to do all the neat little gimmicks. See here? There should be a display telling me how much power is left, but it’s just gone.”

Mustang plays along enough to peer at David’s screen, but slowly shakes his head. “I did not think this is what would get you talking.”

“Nervous habit,” David mutters. “And it’s bugging me.”

Mustang gives a pointed look that makes David hesitate instead of continuing. He says, “Count your words. That is not what bothers you.”

“Count my what?” David shakes his phone. “It worked before. Not for long. Something about going to the Bridge broke it. But I stayed on the call with Lila when I first appeared. Why is that?”

“Count your words, David Adamson.” Mustang, for some reason, gestured towards the storm. “Here on Veneth, and elsewhere where reality flows according to the Paradigms, truth resonates when spoken or sought with five words. It can be circumvented, yes. Even abused. But as a principle, you should note when your words betray a need to veil the truth. That alone can be revealing.

“You have Associated that object,” Mustang continues. “Whatever it was before, it is now also an object that reflects, or even bears, a piece of your soul. It is part of you.”

“How do you know that?”

“I am aligned with Association. I can read Associations easier than others, can manifest my will as an aura in ways that can shift the world. You may be on the road to such an alignment as well, given what you say happened with your device.”

“But still, how can you tell specifically that I’ve turned my phone into a magic item?”

“Two things,” Mustang says. “The first is that the ‘phone’ bears a little of your same aura. It’s faint, but clear enough for me to read. Second, it and the buds you put in your ears share a disturbing property with you.”

“A disturbing property,” David says.

“You are warded.” Mustang stares out at the storm in the distance. “A barrier of Separation—one of the strongest I have encountered—is shielding you from harm.”

“Is that why it felt like my shoulder was digging into your fingers, and not the other way around?”

“Not my only evidence, but yes.”

David asks, “Does it mean something to you?”

“It could mean many things,” Mustang says. “But my concern is that it means more than just the curse of banishing is affecting you.”

More notes in David’s phone:

- *I’m warded.*
- *Curse of Banishing.*
- *Association.*
- *Paradigms.*
- *Separation.*

“I don’t want you dead,” Mustang says. Five words, like he’d said. Stupid that that should make it feel more true. But it did.

“Thanks,” David answered.

“Come. It’s not safe to remain.”

“Shouldn’t we wait for Mere?”

“Mere will find us when it is time. Until then, we should find somewhere to shelter.”

The Falcon Abandons His Sparrow

Darkness is an absence perceived
 Light is perception's gathered quanta
 Our bodies tune to both
 Divining rods with memories
 But tuning breaks the rod



Years later, the Falcon and his Sparrow returned to the Temple of Answered Questions. The Wilds had not shifted in that time, as if fixated on the view of the storms on the Sea of Goletha. Now there was no attendant to the temple, and the young mother had long since moved to the Indomitable City with her child, Thrast.

Mere could catch glimpses of that city from their perch in the open air entrance to the temple. The amber light cast by early sunset washed over the ever-storming sea. It was not quite enough to make the sea seem to catch fire, and part of what defied that effect was the intermittent sight of dark gray walls, high and defiant amidst the turbulent waters. Some had suggested it was not the storms that constantly darkened Goletha, but the city that had been built at its heart.

The people of Goletha were widely regarded as violent and exploitative, using the paradigmatically indestructible walls of their home city as a fortress within which to hoard centuries of plunder they took from the nations that bordered their sea with their massive warships. They permitted no other vessels to weather the storms within, and also refused to agree to the building of a Marshall's Gate within their city's walls. It was of course not the only truth about Goletha. They had taken in the woman and her child without a moment's hesitation on discovering her.

"I could not do it," the Falcon told her again.

She told him she knew.

The Falcon was wrung out. It seemed as if it was difficult enough for him just to sit in silence and watch the distant sea. He would hardly eat. He would hardly speak, except to try to teach Mere more of what she would need to know to take on his mantle when he was finished.

"Why have we returned here?" Mere asked.

He did not answer.

"You did not even give the pretext of repairing the Gate this time. Why do you dwell on that night?"

"Do you remember our meeting?"

"I cannot forget."

The Falcon said, "You have always sworn to me that you did not steal into the Court of the Gods, that the tree you climbed was very nearly outside the city itself. I took this for truth. Something outside of yourself forced you into a necessary moment. Perhaps you were briefly aligned with the dislocation of the Wilds. Perhaps the track of history demanded your presence.

"I have known such compulsions throughout my service as the God of Messengers. Veneth herself at times requires me to carry a message or to bear witness. But nothing has felt so dire a compulsion as to see the birth of that child, and never before have I been commanded by my brethren to defy it with such violence.

"My Sparrow, that child is the herald of ruin, and I am utterly convinced that I have doomed us all by sparing his life."

Mere said, "It seems to me that the child is just a child."

"I can no longer walk a path of conscience," the Falcon said. "I have neither the strength nor the resolve to continue to serve."

Mere scraped her hands in bolting to her feet. She had thought it would be soon, but not tonight. And not this way.

She said, "I am not ready to become the Falcon."

"I am sorry, my Sparrow." He took off the mask.

The world seemed to darken.

For the first time she saw his face, and it was so young. There were no wrinkles or laugh lines. There was none of the leatheriness of aging. But those eyes were hard, dull points. His mouth pulled down tight at the corners. If he felt anything, showing his true face to his apprentice of ten years for the first and last time, he did not show it.

But she could not help but read that expression as disappointed.

With all the animus of a puppet, the man who was once the Falcon swept to his feet and carved a door from the air in a single motion. It was a stone door, matching a little of the aesthetic of the temple. A door for a tomb. The once-Falcon plunged through that door and Mere was forced to follow.

She stumbled out onto the Bridge. This time, her master's will held sway, so the environment that surrounded the bridge was that of the storming sea of Goletha, with patches of golden sunset cliffs that always felt like they were fast retreating into history.

Mere said, "What are you doing?"

His answer was to travel. The weight of his intentional silence carried them along the Bridge in a whorl of motion. Countless doors seemed to pass them in moments. Mere tried to ask more questions about where they were going, or what his purpose was. But for the illusion of moments all she could fathom was the image of the man who had been the Falcon striding down the Bridge with the mask of his office in one hand and the Gilded Sword in the other.

They came to an End with a startling speed. Clearly, whatever resolve remained with the once-Falcon was bent on this. The End was overwhelming. Unreadable. Like standing before the sun itself as it set.

Surprisingly, the Falcon turned to face her.

"Skittering across the realms' border as we do has its cost," he said. "Despite our oaths, and anything we do out of duty, we will find ourselves Separating from the natural order of the place that was once our home. When it is your time to pass on, you too will have to come here to find the closure you will seek. Here at the End of the Bridge is a gate to the ending of all things."

"I beg you to stay," Mere said. This senseless realm did not allow her to move closer to her master—her father.

The Falcon cast the Gilded Sword down at her feet. "There is a tool older than the first of the Hundred Halls. With it you shall skirt the bounds of realms and rend the flesh of the unworthy."

The flare of finality increased. They drew closer to the End. That face she saw so briefly was gone, washed away by the light. She could see only a figure now. Her eyes could only focus on that red-lacquered Falcon mask.

And suddenly the former God of Messengers was in arms' reach.

"This is the heavier weight to carry. Its edges will cut you no matter how you try to hold it. The other Gods swear themselves to Naris' Hundred Halls. You must swear to Veneth herself."

"What if I don't swear?"

He pressed the Falcon into her hands.

"If you cannot find another to carry it for you, the weight will crush Veneth."

"This is what you can stomach?" she demanded. She was frightened. She was furious. "The one thing you can stand to do is to run away and dump it on your child?"

"Be better than me."

The distance smeared again, and from what seemed near a mile off she saw her predecessor standing before the setting sun. Even from that false distance she could perceive the voice that rang out.

"WHO COMES TO STAND BEFORE MY VIGIL?"

And for a terrible moment, Mere felt an attention on her, as she stood with the weight of the Falcon in her hands and the iron of the Gilded Sword at her feet. At first she thought it was the owner of the voice, somewhere in that blazing finality. But no, it was something else, somewhere else on or near the Bridge. It watched her. It pitied her. And it hungered.

She snatched up the Gilded Sword.

Regent and her Rebels Reunited

Mere
 Recluse 

As Mere passes through the threshold of the cave, the world itself twists, causing her to emerge onto the side of a cliff as if from the mouth of the cavern instead of plunging into its darkness. It is as cold and windswept as the Bridge forewarned. She tucks her arms in close, flaring her aura against the mountain gale as she adjusts.

She tries for the simplest way, despite knowing that it will not work. She turns on her heels, meaning to face the cavern entrance she should have passed into when she left the Bridge. The turn carries her farther than she aims, pointing her down a narrow, snow-laden mountain pass. There is a little taste of something like the Wilds here on this mountain. Did she who dwells in the mountain summon that incoherence from elsewhere, create it by raw and potent Associations, or simply discover the property when seeking out a stronghold? A moot question, perhaps, but thinking briefly on it keeps Mere's mind from turning down a worse path. This mountain, at least, does not actually change itself on a whim. It simply tries to turn intruders aside.

In order to counter that redirection, Mere closes her eyes. She pictures Kella in her mind, and of course the version summoned up is that of the frightened child Mere first discovered trying to warm herself in an abandoned cabin deep within the Aspenwood.

"Lo, child," Mere says, allowing the spike of pity she feels at the image to soak her voice. "What troubles you so?"

A presence brushes against Mere's aura as if on accident: Kella sensing the address Mere makes, and the reference and offering within it. But the seer in the mountain shies from the address. Shivering, still, in the cold. Mere, eyes still closed, turns towards the brush of Kella's awareness.

Mere could continue to reference their first meeting, but she need not. It's not those steps she needs to trace here. She pushes forward, not trusting her sight or even her sense of context in the space of the mountain. Instead she trusts in Kella.

As Mere leans into the reluctant care of Kella's Extension, the mountain gale gives one last tug at Mere's coat and hair and aura before it loses its grip. She is inside the mountain now. Though she has been here before and seen firsthand the labyrinthine twists and branching paths of the Caverns of the Seer, there is no time to waste playing games with the incoherence of the mountain. She drives forward, blind and headlong. Dust and small stones crackle underfoot. The chill and sting of the cliffside succumbs to a cozy dry heat. An afterimage of Kella as a child lingers in Mere's memory. She focuses on shifting it older. It's not Kella the child she needs to speak with, but Kella the young woman, whose fears eclipse those of her childhood self.

Mere does not let herself think of the welcoming heat and sensation of tightening as the embrace of a place-as-a-being. She does not permit the semblance of a wolf or a sometimes pleasant buzzing to pierce her defenses. Her thumb tightens against the iron ring on her finger. There are doors you must close in your own mind. Seal them up with mortar. Ignore the noises behind them.

Projecting confidence, Mere opens her eyes to the bedchamber of Kella Aspenwood. It's nothing extravagant: no more than a cavelet nook with a pile of furs as a bed in one corner and a mound of red-hot stones in the other to warm it. Kella sits in the bed, nothing of the shape of their form visible

amongst the furs except a round face veiled in a spray of unkempt dark curls that is currently confined around Kella's head by one of the furs.

Peering out at Mere's arrival, the seer's face is tight with futile attempts to suppress fear, worry, and self-reproach. She says, "He will return, and when he does he will punish us for our insolence."

Mere says, "Thrust has not yet dared to confront me openly." She means it to be reassuring.

Kella says, "Nor you him, until today."

A stab of relief, sharp and hot and quick to drain, to hear that Mere has not lost time to traversing the Bridge. Or at worst, only hours and not days or weeks. She does not hide this from Kella.

Mere says, "With the Circle separated we are blind, and the work is unfinished."

The seer answers, "I witnessed with you how Lenn's game with the guardian ended. We were so short-sighted."

"Yet," Mere says, "we cannot have missed much. For the moment Thrust is gone from Veneth, and we may yet see it so forevermore. But we must work quickly, and for that we need the bond."

"It is not nearly finished," Kella says. "I fear it has scarcely begun. I fear what may be coming. I fear... I fear everything again. The heat won't touch me. The sun in our sky is imagined. I am not reaching but I can feel the foundations of Veneth quiver at his absence."

"Kella," Mere says.

"You could regather the bonds. You are as aligned as I with Extension. I wonder that you feel you need any one of us."

Mere, blank-faced, reminds Kella, "I am not a god."

Of course, Kella's eyes drift pointedly to the pocket where the guise of the Falcon waits. Waits, always, its hunter's cry an older and more haunting voice than the ones behind the mortared door.

Kella says, "I cannot regather the Circle unless first you answer me a question, and then hear out my fears."

A small, easily dismissed prick of alarm.

Kella asks, "Who is the boy?"

Mere says, "A surrogate. An innocent."

"I saw him," Kella says. They shift in their furs. Uncomfortable? Urgent? "Caught glimpses. Portents of what is coming."

"A vision?" As she speaks, Mere asks with a gesture and a step if she may join Kella among the furs. A flicker of assent, but the seer shakes their head at the spoken question.

"Too definite. Too uncertain. Wrapped up in the Paradigms themselves. He and... the wizard... are stamped together now and they turn on these moments of shared alignment:

"The jolt that marks initiation. Stricken by a revenant glare. Emerging from an overwhelming torrent. Snatching for a fading hope. Plunging sword of fatal choice.

"I cannot speak or see them clearer. What comes must end in death, and we sought it out so earnestly."

Mere holds the prophecy as if on her own tongue, weighing it, tasting it. Despite the resonance of five words eminent, she cannot ring out clarity for what is coming. If it is true prediction, then

Kella's glimpses will prove obvious after the fact. But are they even something she can watch for as whatever is coming unfolds? She discerns something from it, though.

"You think Thrast will return?"

A quiet, wide-eyed nod.

Mere places her hand palm up in the furs. That afterimage, again, of her hand placed that way, on a table. Unthreatening, but asking. "If we are scattered when he returns, he will surely crush us."

"I cannot hide from him, can I?" Kella's voice is a whisper, but it echoes lightly in the nook.

"When he realizes what you can do," Mere says, "he will stop at nothing to be rid of you."

A single finger curls around one of Mere's, taut. Kella's head tries to disappear beneath the furs. She mutters something about being a coward.

Mere gently plucks the corner of a fur and pulls it aside, unveiling Kella to the shoulders. They shiver. Mere says, "You threaten his entire paradigm. Where he takes, you give."

"But I have nothing but myself."

Mere snatches her Sparrow into a hug. It startles her, both to think of Kella in those terms and to express it so directly. Perhaps things are now too dire to stifle sentiment. Perhaps the errant gaze of finality rattled something loose. Mere finds herself chuckling into Kella's hair.

"Child," she says. "There is more than enough of you to go around."

It blooms again, that little gleaming ring of connection that is the Circle's bond. The tether resonates with their thoughts, their intents, and the shaping power of their alignments with the Paradigms.

Kella says, her mouth pressed into Mere's coat, "Carry it to them again. I cannot cast it so far. And tell Anshall—"

"You'll tell him yourself," Mere assures. She brushes a thumb across Kella's forehead. Then, as a parting, she says, "Thank you for your courage."

Kella watches Mere go, though it costs her sitting up and the furs dropping away around her, and despite having to do it through tears.



Mere	
	

There is an order to these things. Like the curse cast upon Thrast, establishing the Circle's bond is a ritual with steps. Reality itself follows the order sometimes—always—never quite, depending on the angle. Association: the birth of an idea, the thought before you've had it, the spark of will. Extension: the reach for connection, the plan laid out unexecuted. These Mere has regathered into the Circle in herself and Kella, but the others remain. The hardest, unfortunately, is next.

Domination: the plan in practice, the will ascendant. Lenn, drifting between realms without a tether to any of them, an exile from belonging itself, is the next step in their ritual of re-binding the Circle. To reach him will take patience. To reach him without losing far too much time on Veneth will take astounding luck or the intervention of fate.

Mere returns to the Bridge. Whatever presence had previously shifted the realm's aspect has faded, so the dark and silence that surrounded it is now packed in with whatever contexts the nearby doors bear with them. A half dozen little pleading gates appear that would return her to Veneth. Two doors meander in from neighboring Realms. The ghost of another flickers, though it must be only in her mind, because it dare not risk her attention or the oaths of the Iron Ring.

Going with her gut and the subtle thrust of her shared Extension with Kella, Mere turns her attention to one of the two doors that have presented themselves from outside Veneth. This one is small, shadowed, and susurrating. It is one of the more challenging Realms for her to tolerate on its face, but still safe by comparison. She thumbs the Iron ring and plunges into the darkness. It is not the darkness of the Seer's cavelet, or the void that recently surrounded the bridge. This is a third darkness, that of a place where all that exists is sound.

It is said that the Whispering Void was once a Realm only of splendid music, an eternal chorus creating beauty without the need for other purpose. This has changed. Maybe somewhere in the void there is a pocket of the old songs, but now the Realm is filled with a dreadful silence constantly encroached upon by sibilant whispers worse than the silence itself. Mere enters into this silence as another voice, louder and clearer than the resident voices.

"Lenn," she says, her physicality folded into the sound. It resonates at once like the single syllable of his name and the whole statement of her purpose. ***I call you, Lenn, to trade words with me.***

He does eventually come, but not before the whispering voices who fill the void begin to take up her call. They repeat it until it becomes a low and insistent song filling the silence. Waves of it wash over her, carrying endless permutations of inflection that twist her meaning back on her by peeling free shades of desperation and longing and fear and even anger. Though it's clear they are turning it back on her, it somehow never seems to betray the original note: a grating symphony made by a spoken word dissected, revived, and laid out again endlessly.

Other voices don't take up the song and instead respond to her call by trying to cajole and propose and insinuate their way past her defenses and out of the void to Realms less barren. They seem to sense within her what is kept beyond their reach by a banded hum of ringing Iron that the Ring becomes in this place. There's no escaping them without drawing more attention to herself or departing the realm entirely. All she can do is to endure as they reach past barriers of will that are less than illusory here.

They could never reach it, Kella's voice tells her, a thought they have read in Mere's own heart and brought forth as an assurance. The seer pulls that piece of Mere away like a parent lifting a misused toy above the grasping hands of a petulant child.

Then comes Lenn, and unlike Mere and the residents of the void he appears as himself, not a disembodied voice but a fully visible and tactile man. His condition mocks the realm's own structure. He is accustomed to this by now, as Mere is, but there still seems to be an itch between his shoulders that he refuses to scratch.

No more than a few years prior to Mere's acquaintance with them, Persaval's Separation severed Lenn's Association with the Realm of Veneth herself. Unable or unwilling to bind himself to a new home, Lenn now drifts from Realm to Realm, traveling more freely even than Mere ever could—except that he can never go home, because *home does not recognize him*. But the ties between those who bear unforsaken oaths to each other are not so easily severed. It is by Lenn and Persaval's dedication to each other that Lenn can be bound to the Circle at all. Even that is not sufficient to return him from exile: a reminder to Mere not to underestimate either the deviousness of Thrast or the scale of Persaval's Separation.

Lenn positions himself as if kneeling down to brush the petals of a flower, and says to Mere, “Do you need to be so loud every time you come to this place?”

“It bothers me,” Mere says.

Whispers creep into Lenn’s silence.

“There is a boy,” she explains. “It seems he is the surrogate we didn’t anticipate.”

“Were you looking for confirmation?”

“*Questions*, Lenn.”

“Sorry.” He settles from his kneeling position into sitting cross-legged. “I Commanded reality to produce us someone who would choose to bear this burden for us. Declarations are sour on my tongue at the moment.”

“We’re trusting you on this.” The whispers run away with those five words, flaying surface meaning into a little storm of connotation.

Something to note about Lenn and Domination: he gives himself time. He takes it now, absorbing what Mere says and how the Realm reacts. To watch his face as he does makes Mere keenly aware that she is doing it without a face of her own.

“I broke the Circle,” he says, and this time she feels the honed edge of his words glistening near his own skin. Was that a product of the Void, or his Domination? “Is P—I hope everyone is well.”

“I met with Kella,” Mere says. “Not broken, just scattered. If you are ready...”

Lenn holds up a hand to stop her words. “Tell me of the boy.”

Mere doesn’t want to hesitate. The whispers abhor a contemplative silence. Worse, they echo Lenn’s request as a demand, as instruction. Somewhere in the distance, one of the voices starts screaming. She hesitates anyway. How much did she have the chance to learn of the boy before she sent him away? That he was startlingly quick to do what was required? That the Realm he came from was defenseless against the likes of Thrast? That he had a sister with a sharp tongue? That the boy was as strongly aligned with at least one Paradigm as she had witnessed in anyone, yet she could not say for certain if one of them held a stronger sway?

Mere says “I left him with Persaval.”

Lenn cracks a sad smile.

“What a pair we make,” he says. “You did not brave the whispers just to snap my link back onto the chain.”

“What if I did, Lenn? Do not pretend the Circle means nothing to you. His first thought was of you.”

He answers that so quietly that the whispers still, but his voice is warm, “Don’t lie. His first thought was to make sure the boy wasn’t Thrast in a new guise.”

“You deserve to feel each other again.”

Lenn’s face tightens. For a brief moment, voices begin to take up her words again, but then the Realm of Whispers hushes, except for that one voice that is still screaming. An unspoken stricture from the Realmshorn will not permit them to torment him in that way.

He says, “Mere, what is his name?”

She cannot bring herself to answer.

Lenn says, “You’ve come to me unsure. Are you second-guessing what it will take to fulfill the curse?”

She whispers, “Questions, Lenn...”

He regards her, and she cannot read whether he is cold as ice or restraining himself. That itch between his shoulders seems to have grown.

He starts to read her. His tone becomes pressing. “You’ve spoken with the seer already, and you have a sovereign to assure when we’re done here. Can you do it all in time? What could go wrong if your steps are off?”

“And isn’t that the problem we’re wrestling with here? We found the steps were off. It wasn’t what we thought. Better to be sure, right? And who better to assure you that it doesn’t have to cost what you fear than the man who answered the question that dropped the boy in your lap?”

“Yes!” Mere all but shrieks. “All of that! Why are you so set on dragging it out of me?”

“It is no more cruel than your *being kind* about my husband, Falcon.”

Now she is sure that Lenn is in a cold fury. She has a will like iron. *She* spoke the sealing words of the curse for Thrast. Yet here is this man, banished from belonging itself, treating her like a child at lessons. This man who can cow an entire division of reality with the tightening of his jaw.

“It must be absolutely clear,” Lenn says. “We are talking about whether we must consign a boy who is scarcely more than a child to ignominious death. The thought is *chilling*. We thought we were prepared for stakes like this. We must own that mistake. But there is one thing we must center most, now that we are in this situation:

“We cannot dictate the outcome. We can make our best choices, we can shine and burn and defy Thrast’s horrible, destructive folly. But we cannot be Thrast. What is the boy’s name?”

Mere says, “David.”

“It must be David’s choice. Whatever comes, when David stands before that angel, he *shall not be forced into the choice he makes*.”

“And if he chooses wrong?”

Lenn reaches out his hand as if for her to take it.

Mere meets his extended hand with Association and the binding of the Circle, and the confidence and direction of the Realmshorn returns to the Circle.

Earnest as an oath, he admits, “I yearn for my husband.”



Mere	
	Recusant 

As Mere returns to Veneth from the Bridge again, she emerges this time into the sunset-washed High Hall of Kolomaer. Her passage is through a broad archway (another door, but always open), and as she comes through Mere notices a little clump of snow that has been clinging to her coat somehow even through two disembodied Realms. She snatches it loose between her fingers.

Anshall is a large man, prone to careful movements because of his size, and still he seems only to dangle from the throne of Kolomaer like a doll placed in a chair too large for any one person. Most of this affect is new. A weight drags down the Sovereign's shoulders and quells any fire that might shine in his eyes. This man, who is surrounded by thirty-foot tall columns of gilded marble and who is attended by dozens of scribes, counselors, and adjutants, wears the countenance of someone waiting to die.

An aide startles, and, still unaware of Mere's abrupt arrival, she turns toward Anshall and declaims, "Announcing her grace Mere, the Falcon Goddess of Messengers, bearer of the Gilded Sword and wielder of the Iron Ring, broker of the peace of Harrows and counselor to the High Hall."

Mere gives the aide a slight bow. "Thank you."

"You are, of course, welcome in my court," Anshall says. "But must you compel the members of my court to declare your arrival?"

Mere studies the clump of snow between her fingers. It insists on ignoring the heat of the Kolomaeri evening and maintaining the slight, crunchy give that lightly packed snow usually has. She says, "By your leave, is it not sacred custom in Kolomaer that visiting nobles, royals, and dignitaries be announced when entering the presence of the Sovereign or his representatives? To breach such a custom is considered a curse by your people, and I am who I am. It is Kolomaer that compels them to speak."

This does not seem to relieve the Sovereign or put his attendants at ease. Even here, in a place whose abundant prosperity is so clearly tied to the fortune of their nation's Associations, the folk can be so uncomfortable with the consequences of embracing the strictures of social tradition. Would that they might consider its consequences beyond the odd compulsion towards announcing a guest and into the risks of producing immutable State goods. Coins were one thing, but arms?

"I come bearing news meant for the Sovereign alone."

Anshall nods to the members of his court. "I am happy to entertain a private audience."

His court departs.

When they have gone, Mere says, "We are not yet finished."

"I felt the Circle spring loose and then nothing more. Tell me, does he come for us already?"

Mere crosses the hall while he speaks until she stands before the high seat from which Anshall seems to dangle. She pinches the pellet of snow in her fingers. She says, "Thrust is not on Veneth. Instead, a boy has appeared whom we believe to be bound to our foe. He may be the key to making the curse permanent. The boy is to be guided along a path that will fulfill the intent of our curse on our foe."

"Am I, then, to stamp the Sovereign of Kolomaer's indelible seal on these proceedings?"

"Your support throughout our endeavor to free Veneth has been the foundation without which we could have accomplished nothing. Don't doubt yourself, good Sovereign. There is no Circle without you."

"Yet I sit on this throne, signing papers and sweating blood, while you tread your tireless and sacred path."

Mere steps up beside him. "Do not get it confused. I'm but an errand runner. You're the face of prosperity."

Anshall says, "Surely you recall that his officers in the legion carry swords that bear the seal of Kolomaer?"

Mere says she does.

He continues, "'Nothing that bears the seal of the Sovereign of Kolomaer shall pass away.' My forebears armed him with Eternal Blades. I brokered treaties with him. And now that I have turned against him? He will kill me first."

Her compulsion is to trace her thumb across the Iron Ring, but instead there is that stubborn tuft of snow. She pinches. It gives, but does not break. "If he returns, then yes. Once the Circle is rebound, we can send the Sworn Sword to your side."

Anshall stares through her at that. There is something turning over on his face, which from the history of what he has let flow through the Circle's bond she thinks she can guess at. He is a creature of growth and building, a man aligned forcibly by his station with the Paradigm of Edification. Even before they enacted the curse he often strained against the bonds of that alignment, as if a position of prosperity and sovereignty would serve the same effect on him as a shackle. A man like Anshall is capable of fostering reality from virtually any given choice of action, but is also bound by duty to be certain that the choice he does make is the right one. And here in his High Hall, he gives under the weight of that duty.

"No," he says. "I do not think that will do me any good."

"What do you mean?" Is he refusing Persaval's protection?

Anshall says, "I assume he is currently minding the boy."

"Yes."

"Let him continue. If what you say is true, he is more essential to our efforts than I."

Mere studies that tortured face. Is there a seed of a plan within that turmoil? If so, it's not one he seems willing to share with her.

She steps up beside him and asks, "Will you join your strength to the Circle again?"

He takes her extended hand, and the tenuous bond floods again with presence. She feels years of guilt and doubt break over herself and Kella and Lenn. She feels the response from the others: Kella's quiet and deep affection swallowing up the fathoms of Anshall's uncertainty, and Lenn's certainty and determination smoothing the bond back into equilibrium. Thus steadied, the connection that felt tenuous before now feels almost more substantial than the world around her. The Circle emboldened this way could be a girding around Veneth herself.

An aftershock of heady access to an amount of power she'd briefly lost sends a shudder through Mere, but she accepts this, observes it, absorbs it. She may not have Persaval's full alignment, but she knows how to distance herself from a moment.

She focuses on Anshall's face, where settles a small relief that some portion of him need not dwell in the weight that presses down on him. She keeps a hold of his hand.

"Please don't carry it yourself," she says. "That's not what the Circle is for."

When Anshall pulls his hand away, he is holding that little pellet of snow.

"What is this?" he asks.

She says, "Snow from Kella's mountain."

He cradles it more gently for knowing what it is.

Mere says, "It's more resilient than you might expect."

He says, not looking at it, "And growing."

Then he lowers himself from his throne and lumbers—he used to stride—towards the west, where the sunset spills through the open columns of his court. Mere is carried along by the line of his gaze, but she notes him rolling the tiny snow-ball gently in his fingers.

There is a low wall running between the outer columns of the Sovereign's audience hall. Though it reaches scarcely to Mere's chest and to the bottom of Anshall's ribs, it serves to bar a plunge nearly thirty paces to the next outcropping down the cliff face. The wall is capped with a polished rail in a silvery metal which is stamped in measured increments with the Seal of the Sovereign. The presence of the seal forestalls any rust and even much of the dust that might mar its surface. That unblemished surface currently reflects burnished amber and scarlet light tinged with a blush of pink and lavender. To place a hand on the blazing rail, as they do now, looks almost like touching the sunset itself.

Anshall's gaze is directed beyond and far below into the valley the Kolomaeri mountain overlooks. A massive bank of fog obscures, as it has for more than a century, a handful of broken stone shapes scattered through the valley.

"Did I tell you how it felt to meet you for the first time?" he asks.

She shakes her head.

"Now that I think of it, I had a warning first. A letter appeared one morning upon my desk. It was not sealed, and it simply said, 'The Falcon returns to Veneth.'

"There was rumbling in my courts. I myself made much of it. One of the storied Gods of our neighbor and rival in antiquity was rumored to return, and it was the one with whom we'd shared the best rapport? The nation bubbled with questions of how and to what end, until you finally appeared.

"You were a wild woman. Dazed, it seemed at first. I know now it was layers of righteous fury. The only right course was to offer you the best hospitality the High Hall could afford you. And to heed your counsel, once you could give it.

"I was already wracked with guilt for leading my nation in impasse while the wizard wove his will through our political rivals and client states. When I heard that someone from the Hundred Halls persisted today, I dreaded your wrath.

"You did not bring wrath. You brought me truth instead. And from truths we once forsook or never knew I thought I saw a hope that we might set this right together. I have not forgotten that."

All the while he rolls that pellet in his finger like a jewel. He does not look at it, but his fidgeting keeps drawing her eye. He's rolled it smooth and round and tightly packed. It's packed so tightly now, in fact, that the curved surface of the snow-ball catches some sheen off the evening radiance. Under his fingers it is no longer a clump of snow but a pearl of ice.

Anshall turns his gaze on Mere and says, "You ask us not to carry our weight alone. You're right, of course. The things we bury have a tendency to grow on us."

"What is it you're thinking?"

"I think I shall die. Now please, I know that our time is short. It is yours to run errands, and it is mine to wait. You have my support, now close the Circle and solve this."

Sunset. Stormwinds. Sworn Sword Sear.

David		
	Apace	

On the long walk to reach something like shelter, it's the quiet that hits David hardest. He expects it, based on everything he's read about how much more background noise there is to the modern world even in the rural parts, but just as soon as he has acclimated to the distant thunder of the storm over the ocean, the gentle expanse of plains-grass under open sky unlatches a part of him like a suitcase and lets the tangled, bunched-up fabric crammed inside bust free of its containment. He isn't prepared for it. He's too stunned to cry but it feels like he should and that dissonance makes its own little whirlpool. That whirlpool spirals around the line bolted to his center that continues drawing him, like Mustang's back, towards the storm and the ocean. But in all of it, he breathes deep, and when he exhales it feels like he grows a little more back into shape.

Is there a different quality to the air here? Something strange about the way the air hangs or sighs around him? Is there anything alien about this grass, that during this stretch or the other rises above his head? If there is, he's not catching it. The alien from his world, the endlessly repeating pillars bearing power lines and the painted asphalt roads, has no analogue that he can see here. Aside from the courtyard they'd emerged onto at first, there's no trace of what might have been a civilization here.

"Where did the roads go?"

Mustang glances back at him. At first he'd kept David in front of him, still protective, but after what David guessed (and meant to track with the stopwatch app on his phone but forgot about) was an hour, Mustang drifted ahead to more easily guide the way. He asks what David means about the roads.

David says, "If that Gate was important to transit for this area, wouldn't there be roads between it and nearby settlements? Especially the big ones."

"Overgrown," Mustang guesses. "Veneth works quickly."

"But not on the stones of that courtyard."

"Apparently not."

"So roads are not so magic here, I guess." He adds it to his notes.

"'Magic' in what sense?" Mustang asks back. "Paradigmatic consequence?"

"Uh..." David stumbles over another hidden stone. "So this might be a weird question, but what language are we speaking right now?"

"We call it 'midspeech' in Ea'river. Kolomaer names it as the Trade-tongue."

"So, the go-between language for this part of the world."

"Yes."

"And you understand everything I say?"

"The words, yes. Your intent is not always clear. But that is how language functions, yes? Everything is mutually understood, except sometimes meanings that are hidden to the speaker, the listener, or both."

“That’s not how it works,” David says. He counts his words after the fact, when Mustang whirls around and gives him a scowl. David swallows. It’s a hard face this man has, worn smooth of many of its readable expressions. The one on Mustang’s face now would normally push David into a panic, scrambling for something to say that can scrub over whatever social error he must have just made. But something about the way Mustang has acted protectively so far, and what Mustang has said about the magic that seems to shield David from harm, gives him space to breathe and read that expression deeper.

It is not a scowl. It’s Mustang trying to read David, finding him somehow mutually inscrutable.

Mustang says, “You did that by accident.”

David finds his footing again, “If you run into someone from the other side of the world, they’re going to be from a group of people with a different history than yours. They’re not going to even use the same mouth sounds to mean the same things. Probably won’t even have the same grammar. Maybe it won’t be five words for them. Or that’s how it works where I’m from.”

“I had not thought to learn about Veneth from a visitor. But you are right, I can read it now. Here on Veneth, the meaning of our words is conveyed directly.”

“So I could be speaking English to you right now,” David says. “My language, and it might as well be the same, because magic.”

“You asked about this because I was uncertain what you meant by ‘magic.’ This seems to be a difficult meaning for Veneth’s Association to align, because that word as I hear it means somehow tricking or cheating the world, or our understanding of it, to make something you want happen that might be unexpected. But the Paradigms, and alignment with them, are not a way to exploit a gap in the rules. They’re ways to understand our world, and how it flows.

“I feel my husband could better explain it...”

“Magic doesn’t exist on Earth,” David says. “It’s an idea people have. ‘What if the world worked this way instead?’ What if that weird old lady who lives out in the woods because we don’t like how she looks and smells cursed our fields and that’s why the harvest was bad?”

“So when we figure something out on Earth that helps us, some quirk about the way the world works, we call it science. We give it different language. We prove it by repetition. But it doesn’t work like your Paradigm stuff, your swords that carve doors to other realities and your universal translator-planet. It’s stuff we make using careful application of what we’ve learned using very precise tools on very specific materials, like my phone. It takes an enormous amount of work, of cleverness, and, usually, forcing people to sacrifice themselves for the product.

“The kinds of things you can do are the things we’d call magic, there.”

“Then perhaps we can hope that Thrast is stifled in your realm, if it is so hostile to the flow of Veneth.”

“Is it?” David asks. “I’m here.”

Mustang says, “Hrm.”

“Do you know what was up with my earbuds being a chunk of amber for a hot second?”

Pause. “I thought I was mistaken.”

Mustang stops to turn towards David, pulling something from his coat. It’s a polished chunk of amber, gleaming in the afternoon light.

David steps a little closer. Is something moving in there?

Mustang says, “In Ea’River we revere amber. She is also Veneth’s daughter, bound in the forgotten past.”

“Veneth’s daughter?” David peers, watching blurred pale shapes sweep across some inner surface of the amber.

“Born of her, like humanity.” Mustang is watching the shapes, too, but his gaze is practiced. David is quickly distracted from the gem as he notices that the shapes are reflected in Mustang’s eyes as if he is watching them move from feet away. In the gleam of a pupil David sees a tiny figuration of a younger Mustang, all in white and gold and shoulders wreathed in what seemed like unfurled scrolls. That miniature Mustang reaches the center of some altar or stage and plants his bladeless sword in front of him as he takes the classic position of a knight about to swear an oath to some new allegiance. The wind almost sounds as if it’s carrying a chorus of distant voices, many calling out, and Mustang calling in response.

“For Veneth shall I stake my life and death.” That’s the voice of *this* Mustang, spoken low as the vision of his past smears out the glass of his eyes to be replaced by a little mirror of David’s own face. He says, in a much more present voice, “Amber shows you what was. Sometimes a glimpse of what will be, or could be. But as with Veneth herself, Thrast claimed mastery over the ambered histories.”

He tucks the little yellow-orange chunk away. “Perhaps in his absence it reclaims a little of its mischief.”

David spouts, “Amber comes from tree sap. Gets hardened over time. Sometimes catches little bugs or bits of leaf inside.”

“Sometimes,” Mustang notes as he starts off again, “amber comes from the beasts of the sea.”

David keeps up.

As the shoreline creeps over the horizon, he can’t help compare it to the big water he knows best: Lake Michigan. He retains some basic facts you learn when you’re raised in the Mitten State: that the Great Lakes are, by volume, basically the largest inland freshwater seas in the world—or at least on Earth; that the lake is frequently the subject of corporate and public interest alike; that in Michigan, at least, there is no such thing as a private beach, legally, since significant bodies of water are public property. These little facts scatter him into several asynchronous and semi-conscious trains of thought.

Lightning cracks the sky, and the thunder that follows is distant but still rattles his chest. His comparisons carry him first to memories of lake effect snow burying the neighborhood overnight, and then to schoolbook info-graphics of hurricanes that Michigan has never suffered from in his memory. It strikes him that this sea should feel to him like it dwarfs the comparatively calm lake not an hour west of his hometown, but instead it’s the storm itself that makes him feel small.

“Before we take shelter, there is something I need to see to,” Mustang says. “It has taken time to perceive it, but the balance of Veneth’s Associations have shifted in Thrast’s absence.”

“Shifted how?”

“That is not yet clear.” Mustang gestures towards the towering storm and the shoreline. “But there are Works of his here in Qastra I can review. The Shining Legion has served him since before I was born.”

At length, a new feature of the landscape helps David piece together Mustang’s sparse explanation. It’s a stone fortress: ramparts, watchtowers, a central keep, the whole works. The thing

caps off a hillside like an oversized hat, and for a good mile in either direction the grasses of the plains are replaced with regimented fields. A pristine little lake claims a whole field-space of its own, and there are some docks and netting and fishing boats. All of that tracks to David. It reads as something he can expect from the sort of world he's been hauled into by fate's grim fishing line.

What doesn't track is that the manor grounds are empty. The boats are bound up, some bobbing in the gentle movement of the lake's waters and others pulled up dry. No one tends the fields. No one has any market stalls up, or is hauling carts to or from the castle. There's at least one field that seems like it should clearly be a pasture, but there are no animals there to graze.

Over the horizon, the storm crackles with growing displeasure.

David hears himself ask, "Where is everyone?"

Mustang's head has been on a swivel, but he takes a moment to center on David. He sets a hand on David's shoulder as if to steady him. The sensation of feeling his shoulder *press* Mustang's fingers instead of a mutual pressure is more disconcerting while they're not wandering an abstracted void space.

Mustang says, "I fear that the roads of Qastra have gone the way of its people."

David feels all the muscles in his jaw tighten and fights not to let his teeth grind together. "Is this place not in ruins for the same reason that the Marshall's Gate is still standing?"

"Perhaps." Mustang releases David once he's sure that the implications aren't driving David to his knees. "Though the forces of that preservation are more immanent here."

Mustang guides them slowly closer to the castle and its grounds. It strikes David, after looking at the landscape long enough, that there is something else odd about this place, other than that it appears to be freshly abandoned. It's the little hills, dividing the fields into rows. They are all roughly the same height and breadth, and each and every hill has a decorative stone gate carved into it. They can't be houses because there are enough hovels above ground to house plenty of folks. But he doesn't believe they could be *burial mounds* until Mustang brings them near to the closest of the hills.

The stone door is carved in relief with the image of an armored warrior, shield raised and sword held low at his side. There's no way this could be anything other than a tomb for honored dead. Still, with so many mounds, and no one around....

"They're dead," David says. "Everyone. It's a city of the dead."

"Close," Mustang says. He gestures for David to stay put, pulls his not-sword from its scabbard, and moves close enough to knock against the door with the blunt white end of his weapon.

The knock sounds hollow behind the door, and is followed by a long low groan.

David says, "Fuck."

Mustang says, "Barrow Knight of Qastra, I come seeking peaceful parley and no further disturbance of your rest."

The groan repeats, more loudly. There is a scraping and shuffling sound. David takes a step back.

The vocalizing slowly resolves into a "U" sound, distinct enough for him to make out when that sound shifts up and back to "ay."

A minute passes, and with a kind of slurping and a reciprocated knock on the inside of the door, a voice from inside asks, "Where have you sent him?"

Mustang does not answer, seeming disturbed by the question.

The door jostles and starts to slide open. Mustang makes space, his not-sword down at his side in a position not unlike how the warrior on the relief holds his.

"I don't feel his hand at my back." A realized image of the warrior on the door is revealed as he finishes pushing aside the seal to his own tomb. Tall. Would be handsome, if not for the scraps of dead skin sloughing from his bald head, to be replaced by fresh flesh. One of his eyes is clouded white and oozing something black. He seems to be fighting against blinking against it. The sunlight does not phase him. He says, in perfect English (or mid-speech), "I have been lying awake in my crypt, wondering what urgency should wrest me from my slumber. Wondering if the lack of him was punishment for some failure of mine to keep the oaths."

"Nay, good knight, you hold your oaths true," Mustang says.

"Alas," the waking dead man says. "I can not trust the word of a traitor and oathbreaker. You were sworn to serve Him too, riverman. Now what have you done?"

The warrior's armor is rusted in places, but well-preserved. His fist, wrapped in a half-rotted leather glove, grips the hilt of a sword he carries by the sheath.

To David, Mustang says, "I had almost hoped that they would be free, but his grasp reaches beyond the veil of Veneth. This is Thrast's man, beyond death and to the end of all things."

"As you were to be!" The warrior rattled his sword, as if threatening to draw it. "He woke us once, all those who were not on the tour of service that saw you swear new oaths. He told us of your righteous fire, and how in his service you would do as much for Veneth as a hundred years of our service had done. We were proud to learn we had an oath-brother from Ea'river. Proud you learned our Oaths. Did you think you were clever enough to escape their weal?"

"Good barrow knight," Mustang says. "Our oaths are alike in spirit but not in effect. And you were told false: I never swore to Thrast."

"You lie!" The warrior's face goes grim. that clouded eye clears, the last of its necrotic tissue expelled onto the collar of his plate. Solemn and furious, he draws a blade of gleaming, perfect steel from its sheath. "You are an oathbreaker! You have forsaken your honor. I am bound with all those sworn alongside me to harry you until your oath is made fast again to its just place. Ready yourself, Persaval of Ea'River."

"I stand ever ready to uphold my oaths, good knight. I shall even entertain your challenge, if you prove your oaths retain some of their substance. Are there any in Qastra who have not sworn to the legion?"

The warrior snarls. "Why should there be? What honor is there to remain aloof to the most just cause?"

A single tongue of autumnal flame licks up the clean white lacquer of Mustang's weapon. "Do not mistake me, Knight of Qastra. You are sworn to defend all the folk of Qastra, regardless of oaths unsworn, broken, or held true. Your oath compels you beyond the bounds of death, and it compels you beyond the bounds of will or knowledge. Speak a true answer, and then harry me as you may."

A shaking arm shifts unbidden by its master, using the silvery tip of a sword to gesture towards the shore. "There are such folk of Qastra as you seek near the shore of Goletha. They shiver in their caves, fearful to be discovered. The storm will soon devour them, as it has many such hives of cowardice amongst our people."

"I accept your answer, knight." Mustang fills the space between himself and the warrior with his sword.

"What makes Thrast so just?" David asks.

The warrior finally seems to notice that Mustang did not knock on his tomb alone. He peers past Mustang, bewildered.

"Sorry," David says. "I'm not from here. What's your measure for justice? Is there a code, or a set of laws, or is it just vibes?"

The warrior points his sword at David. "Who is this unblooded child? Why does he bear some shadow of the graces?"

David says, "I'm some kind of accident. Unintended consequences, I guess. But before you ignore me and have your grand duel, could you answer the question? How did Thrast get you to trust him?"

"He showed us what would come of this world did we not serve at his instruction. Chaos. Senseless death. The Wilds unchecked."

"The Wilds?"

"He is an idiot, this child? Or very sheltered?"

Mustang says, "He is insatiably curious and very young."

"And yes, a bit stupid," David adds. "You ever hurt an innocent person? You ever stand by and let an innocent person get hurt when you could help?"

The warrior stares, his perplexity hardening into anger.

"Do you believe in innocence? Or is everyone guilty by default: of not swearing an oath, of not swearing the right one, of being from the wrong place, or loving the wrong sort of people?"

"David?" Mustang actually gestures for him to calm down.

For David, the only person in the conversation without a weapon, to dial it back?

"How thin do the justifications get once you're a bag of bones rotting in a tomb? I just wanna know. Does Thrast have the juice? Is he so bomb at speeches that you cannot fathom but for having to hand it to him? Or are you clinging to the last thread of something that gave you meaning on the edge of a void that you, what, are forbidden to ever sink into?"

The warrior roars and surges forward, trying to barrel past Mustang and get to David. He makes it two steps before he's engulfed in flames. But he keeps roaring as his flesh catches and burns away. Keeps roaring as he crashes into *nothing*.

"What have you done with him?" Voice broken and crackling like the rest of him. "Where did you and this Lost One send him?" That sword shines stubbornly on, even as the rest of the warrior's armor burns or begins to take on an orange hue.

David hears himself snap, "Do you even want peace? Or is this what you crave, to live forever fueled by a self-righteous grudge?"

Mustang says softly, "Stop it."

"No, let him try it."

"I will not indulge you."

The warrior breaks his arm against a wall David can't see, and it immediately sets. Hot, ashen clumps of tears and cooked flesh drip down the warrior's face.

"What's the worst that can happen?" David says. "Either he can't hurt me, or I die a little prematurely and none of this was as clean and pat as you all want it to be."

"You've missed the point entirely."

Mustang steps past the warrior again and, holding his blazing weapon out, marches forward, driving the warrior's macabre mime act backward until he is back inside his tomb. Then, with a blow that must have had more to it than the force of the strike, Mustang breaks the frame of the tomb's entry. Stone and dirt and grass tumble down as the whole thing caves in.

"Run. That will only delay him."



David does what he is told. As he scrambles back up the path that had led to the warrior's barrow, Mustang / Persaval quickly overtakes him, and then David's vision narrows to a murky bouncing window. His breath comes heavy. He trips over ruts and stones. Before long his body *aches*. He doesn't run like this. He doesn't do *anything* like this.

He can hardly keep a bead on Mustang. It mostly feels like staggering towards a lamp in the darkness. The whole time, some parts of him try to form thoughts into a regimented civil conflict, cynical versus contrite, outrage against shame, disdain against fear. These thoughts are vapor, and each haphazard step is like an oar sweeping through them.

The clearest thought to come to him first does so when the muscles in his stomach and the backs of his legs seize up and drop him to the dirt. The thought that comes is that he can't be as invincible as he thought if his body can break down from a few minutes of hard running, but the echo of it is the note that hitting the ground doesn't hurt in the slightest.

Mustang doesn't turn to face David. He just stands there, hardly winded, waiting for David to recover. He's not even seething. Impassive, measured silence from him, while David tries not to hyperventilate.

Finally, he turns his head a little and says, "That was poorly done."

David gulps down some air, twisting his body to a more comfortable position. He doesn't find an answer before Persaval goes on.

"Do you wish for death?" he asks.

David says, "No." It's not a lie, technically. This time.

"The Barrow Knights may be a threat to us and a tool of Thrast, but they are also his victims."

David says, "He sounded like a cop."

"These 'cops' of your world, are they also bound by rules of service?"

"They're supposed to be, but they're just strongarms for the guy in charge."

"And you caught enough similarity to Associate the fallen knights of a foreign world to the failings of your own?"

"I don't know. Maybe people are just people."

Persaval turns fully, but his eyes are on the path behind them. Probably watching for the dead. “What is it that you have suffered, to make despair your first response even when you are so young?”

“Mistrusting the tools of authority isn’t despair.”

“Jumping at the chance to die for something *is*.”

David struggles to his feet. “Do we need to keep moving?”

Persaval says, “Yes.”

“Then let’s go.”

“We’ll walk for now. I need to tell you where we are bound now, but I want to prepare you.”

“I have a guess, but I’ll save it.”

They walk. It’s quiet, except for the sound of their steps and those of the distant storm, and its winds.

Persaval says, “Holding someone accountable to their oaths is not the problem. Suggesting the likely truth that he will seize on anything that gives him purpose was only ever going to make him lash out.”

David says, “Is he more like you or more like me?”

“My oaths are much like those he swore, and I have heard you swear no oaths.”

“But here I am, brought and kept in this world against my will for a purpose I have no choice but to agree to.”

“And you believe that purpose is to be sacrificed for the sake of Veneth.”

“And Earth. It would be worth it, right? To get rid of Thrast.”

They leave the path behind. They veer toward the shoreline and the storm.

Persaval says, “It’s a choice only you can make. But David of Earth, we make an endless series of choices before the end of our days, and I fear that if you make each of those small choices as if it is the one that will end you, that you will not make the right choice when the time comes.”

“I’m not trying to get myself killed.”

“Can I take your word, then, and trust that when I seek to protect the Qastrans at the shore you will do your best not to interfere?”

“What? Yes! You have my word I won’t get in your way. Even help if I can.”

Persaval guides them on after that in silence. David accepts that silence, even though it feels like letting himself get engulfed by a fog heavy with the conversation that preceded it. He trudges after Persaval through this mist, hardly noting changes in terrain and temperature or the ache of his body’s protests to their pace.



It’s the wind that rouses him. It howls past the two of them, and in passing casually tosses David off his feet. Landing on his ass doesn’t hurt, just a numb sort of of the impact and the jolt to his sense of balance. Persaval stops and turns, and all at once the rushing wind is silenced.

"That was different," Persaval says.

David gives him a dazed look. They've been descending some old trail that wends against a rising cliff face. That must be why the wind is so rough, it's careening off the growing wall Persaval is keeping to their right.

"You have fallen several times. Some of them were falls that could have broken a bone even for a resilient youth, and have not so much as scuffed your clothing. All of those were, and I do not mean this derisively, the fault of your own clumsiness. But here, the wind..."

David climbs to his feet and habitually dusts himself off. Persaval's right that there isn't really anything to brush loose. He says, "You think there's something *pointed* about this storm? We're up against an anvil here." He gestures to the cliff face.

Persaval says, "A storm that always rages *over the waters of Goletha* is raiding the coast of Qastra, and its winds are the first that dare to test the warding graces that surround you?"

"I'm not hurt, at least."

"Perhaps I am looking for answers where there are only the wild whims of Veneth to be found," Persaval admits. "That unyielding storm has always disquieted me, and until Mere, or the Seer, or someone with a broader sense for omens can dispel my fears, it's in my nature to suspect that every ill wind may be a servant of Thrast's lingering will."

David asks, "Is this the only way to the shore?"

Persaval says, "There's another garrison of the Barrow Knights atop this cliff. The free peoples of Qastra would not congregate there. So it is down, into the howling, if I am to fulfill my duty to protect the vulnerable."

Still a little dazed, and still a little frustrated, David doesn't bother thinking of something to say in response. Instead, he just flips the storm a double deuce.

To that, Persaval is also robbed of his words. He observes the gesture, lets out a muted gruff chuckle, and says, "Quite."

They start off again, this time surrounded in a veil of silence that David can almost *see* the edges of. The winds rustle grasses and trees and kick up little clouds of dust all until they come within like a fifteen foot radius of him and Persaval, then all evidence that the winds are raging is stifled.

"You doing that?" David asks.

"Yes." Persaval tentatively raises a lonely middle finger toward the storm, shrugs, and they carry on.



"Thrast used that belief to become the Prophet of History, and twisted my entire nation to his will."

"Never mind that sucks. Is that what he does to everything?"

Mustang doesn't say he's sorry, but the tension in his shoulders carries more than naked apologies. "Yes."

"You used his name."

"Association, as is common on Veneth. Without other Paradigms, or as one who is isolated from others, Association is almost useless. But I have found uses for it."

“Is that the names thing?”

“And the fire.”

“Fire?”

“Association is bound up with each person’s essence, and the essence of a life is commonly viewed as a flame: death is like snuffing out a candle, and a beloved person illuminates a room for others. Emotions are often felt as heat within the body. Because of this, what gives you meaning and purpose, that which kindles your passion, can be drawn out from associations into actual flame by those so Aligned.”

“I gotta say, a lot of this Paradigm stuff is sounding like tricks of the light.”

“Is it not so where you are from? How much of your world is dictated by perspective? How often do perspectives win out that shelter those who hold them from seeing the harm caused by their actions? Light is what it is, and we must choose where and how to shine it.”

“I guess I shouldn’t expect anything else from a guy who wants to go by ‘Arbiter.’ So have you figured out what went wrong yet?”

Mustang pauses and sniffs the air. He holds one hand out from his side and buries his fingers in the grass, feeling the wind play the blades across his fingers. He says, “My part in the curse was to supply the chisel that would part Thrast from Veneth. In keeping myself protected while I supplied that chisel, I was not party to the way Mere swung the hammer, or which bucket was selected for the shavings to fall. Mere left to gather the others and the knowledge we lacked.”

“So someone knows?”

“He might,” Mustang says. “But I will not know for sure unless Mere brings word from him. He and I are Separated.”

“Who is ‘he?’”

“I think you would like him.” Mustang starts up the path again. He’s moving faster. “He is also fond of questions.”

“Wait a minute. Is something happening?”

“As you said, it is a long walk.”

They run. The storm rises up into the sky like Zeus is getting ready to smite just this one specific village. The grass is gradually choked out with stones and sand. Mustang grows increasingly urgent, but he never leaves David behind. David can’t decide if Mustang is concerned for him or waiting for him to zombify. David’s legs and side and lungs protest, but slowly they seem to accept the new state of suffering. He takes it one breath and three stumbling steps at a time.

It does help that when he falls he doesn’t get scratched, and that the pounding headaches he sometimes gets when he overworks never come. Maybe he can get used to this. Maybe it will help him get in shape.

Finally, the village comes into view. It is no larger than David imagined, just a small handful of thatched huts on a hill overlooking a beach with several boats that have been dragged ashore and lashed to something that might hold them in place. There are no people visible outside the huts, and David hopes there aren’t any people inside the huts either, because the proximity of the storm is destroying his balance. It feels more like the beach and the path are on the surface of a satellite hanging over the actual planet, the storm; any second David and Mustang and the village are going to lose their grip on the surface and plummet into the ire that waits below. But David asserts to

himself that the storm is neither up nor down, it's over there, and no matter how close and overwhelming it is the storm hasn't upended reality (because something else has already done that).

When Mustang catches sight of the village, he breaks into a true sprint, stopping for neither David or sure footing until he is standing in the center of its little gathering of huts. David stumbles after, feeling a wave of something press past him and enclose the village like a bubble. The wind dies down. Mustang stands with his hands outstretched, his face dark and scrunched together.

Someone steps out of her home, peering out to see why the world has suddenly stilled. She looks between Mustang and the storm a few times. Then, her head turns sharply and she disappears back into her hut. David glances in the direction her head turns and he wishes he had a tent flap he could hide behind.

At the far end of the fishing village the hill the village rests on rises again, and there's part of a stone building sticking out of that rise with a huge pair of doors closing the entrance to a cave. The ponderous doors of the barrow have slammed open, and a man has emerged, clad in the armor he was buried in and holding a gleaming sword out towards Mustang. His torn and rotting flesh is knitting itself back together, and regaining a healthy color, but the look of hatred in his eyes only deepens.

Without the screaming wind to drown it out, the soldier's words carry to David's ears ever-so-clearly. "So long as there is need on Veneth for a righteous blade, the Shining Legion will rise to meet that need!" He marches out of the barrow's doorway, and there are four other soldiers following him. They, too, are healing from decades of time among the dead. "Persaval of Ea'river, you have broken your oath to the Lord Commander of the Legion and carved out the very Soul of Veneth! Stand, traitor, and answer for your sin!"

David feels his knees lock up. That hook in his brain tugs, sending a wave of nausea through him. He keels over into the dirt.

Mustang doesn't respond.

The revenant soldiers form up outside the barrows. With one voice they cry, "Riverman, you stand accused! Speak your answer!"

Without turning his eyes from the storm, Mustang tells David, "This is what he does. In his fervor to prevent the ruin of all things, he has undone Veneth one nation at a time."

"Blasphemy!" scream the soldiers. They charge.

Mustang's look of concentration doesn't change, but he does pull his not-sword out. It licks with fire as it's drawing free, and the tongues of the fire leap to the growing and curl around the feet of the charging soldiers. Then small flickers become an instant bonfire, engulfing all of the soldiers in the flames.

The screams are terrible.

Persaval takes a deep breath. He turns away from the storm and to the soldiers, who were only slowed by his fire. They pick their way out of it, covering in hideous burns that are already blistering and falling away to be replaced by fresh pink skin underneath. One of the soldier startles as he rises again, his almost glowing eyes shifting off of Persaval and then past him. At David.

The soldier screams again, as if he still on fire. "What have you done to the Lord Commander? Why do you wear his graces?"

David stammers, and a wave of fire knocks the soldiers back again. But now the attention of all five soldiers is on David. Their glares seem to dig through his eyes and scramble for the knot tied to him. His heart squeezes itself up into his throat.

And then David is gone.

The Falcon, By Wolf Devoured

Does Mere, the Goddess of Messengers, know anything of joy?

Mere
 Once 

Mere delivers a formal letter declining an offer of courtship to a young officer in Qastra (where are they? how does that inform the introduction?). The lad, not much younger than Mere, is relieved to have confirmation of his suspicion and also immediately enamored with a mysterious woman carrying messages while hiding her face behind the visage of a falcon. He immediately attempts to win her attention and even her affections.

Mere, having never received such attention, reacts with a mix of shock and intrigue. She permits herself to remain and allow the young man to ask her about herself.

From this conversation, she is made keenly aware how little, still, of her life has been of her choosing. Sensing her shift in mood, and general grave demeanor, he asks her “does the Goddess of Messengers know anything of joy?”

In answer, she brings him to a field of flowers kept cultivated near to the Marshall’s Gate outside the city. The young man clearly seeks intimacy. He wants to see the face she will not show to others.

She is hesitant, but eventually agrees. He kisses her, she reciprocates, and they have a tryst in the field of flowers.

After, he talks about the oaths he will need to take to finish becoming an officer of the Legion, and that he hesitated to be pressed to that degree of service. He does not want to be bound to something bigger than himself. He wants small life, small love, and maybe to see the world.

Mere offers to show him something more than their world. She takes him through the Gate to the Bridge, showing him the many doors the Realm presents to them, which ones lead back to Veneth and which go Elsewhere.

He asks if she has ever been to Another Place, just to visit. She reflects that her mentor forbade it, citing how different and dangerous another world can be. But he tells her that she is not wearing the mask now, that they both can return to their duty later, and what harm is there in paying a simple visit?

They select a door that is a passage between two trees, and from which the scent of honey wafts. It is a door to Harrows, and they pass through it.

At first their visit is pleasant. There is honey and fruit and warmth and beauty. But the world also seems to shift around them. Time slips away from them. The young man is claimed first, seized with a need to remain, and he convinces her to stay as well. She crafts a set of rings for them out of grass. She slowly begins to forget Veneth, and her concerns over the Wilds and Thrast.

And one day, the young man is gone. Does he become a wolf? Is he literally eaten by Harrows? By whatever means, it becomes clear that the place Mere has come to is a predator, and it does not mean to let her leave.

With great effort and striving, she uses her lingering Associations as the Falcon to carve her exit from Harrows, but that is not enough. She has to bind the place away from the Bridge and from

Veneth (because it means to follow its prey beyond the bounds of its own existence). It is Harrows that turns her grass ring to Iron. It is the Falcon who swears an oath.

This ring's purpose was stolen. It cannot be returned, because it was a promise and it was broken. So long as I still wear this broken promise, this Iron Ring, the thief of that purpose is barred the passage of any door and cannot seek shelter without being driven off.

But the promise, broken, lingers. And this place, harrowed and harried by her curse, harrowing for those who touch it, lingers in Mere's mind. She cannot eject it without releasing her curse, because it was already within her, and leaving her would be passage through a door.

That kind of bond, but without the rage and judgment and compromise to something terrible, is the inspiration of the nature of the Circle's bond (which is why this is the Edification flashback for Mere).

From the Brink of Oblivion

I could tell this was the bottom

Because it is so heavy

And I felt every ounce



When Annabeth Oakley was presented with what her descendants would call the Oakley ring, it was set with a modestly-sized garnet. Annabeth then gave it to her daughter Rebecca, represented by a sardonyx of similar size. Rebecca added a sapphire for Jenna, but she also had another setting prepared when she did, so that when Jenna handed the ring down to Lila she was compelled both to fill a setting with Lila's amethyst and prepare another empty one, where the gem from Lila's daughter would continue the tradition. Like Rebecca, Jenna never discussed this expectation with her daughter. She only gave Lila the ring and said, "My mother gave me this when I came of age. Now I'm giving it to you."

In lieu of the expected precious stone, the eye of the flower is a small, gleaming ember. Within the ring the slurry of fear and anger that is panic spills into a chasm, and a dozen other lesser but still stringent colors of passion contribute to the blackbody radiation the band of the Oakley ring is now emitting in the visible spectrum. Thus, the inside of Lila's car is on fire.

How does a mind work after it has been crammed into a smartphone? Synapses are traded for chip-sets. Organic, near-quantum concurrency is boxed into an abstract syntax tree and the cognitive executive moves from theoretical to the phenomenological experience of manually operating the CPU's fetch, decode, and execute steps. Every piece of information she receives becomes bits, or packets of bits. Time stretches out into a series of cycles, hundreds of times a second, tagged with information about what fraction of a second exactly the last cycle took.

The parts of Lila that evaluate information, sort it, and enable her to act on it are cut off from her. She cut them off. So the vessel from which she'd planned to conduct her newly partitioned life instead leaves her mind wrestling with streams of electrons governed by logic gates she lacks the perspective to understand. And while the mind wrestles, the flames of decentralized panic only grow hotter.

Separated from mind and spirit to govern the engine of her will, the body that houses her Domination lies dormant. Without the essence of life to fuel the engine and foster those infinitesimal deeds of her cells necessary to continuously maintain everything that makes an organism alive (firing synapses, respiration, circulation, cell division, biochemical combustion...), Lila is, simply, dead.

Her homespun scarf spins more of itself, seeking life to foster and chaos to bring to order. But without models to follow, paths to take, or the will to do, the threads (like sprouts) can only grow towards a source of energy. Most, then, spread too close to the ring and are consumed by the rising

flames in the cabin of the car, but in doing so they provide a buffer between her corpse and self-immolation.

The buffer will not last forever. The hand that wears the Oakley ring is already a smoldering husk, and the heat is crawling up to consume more of her arm. A magnificent intent means nothing if you lack the will to take it up.

If the Oakley ring is her spirit inflamed, her phone is her scattering mind, her body is her dormant flesh suit, and her scarf is aimless Vita, then what is or will become of the jacket with which she made her disastrous division? It is the scalpel dropped between the tray and the table; it is the walls of a tower built without doors or windows. Yes, the same lines drawn to Separate her vessels are keeping much of the heat of her spirit from consuming her other selves, but the heat licks through unmanned gaps in those walls. Her Edge should have written a comma between “I will partition myself” and “and then I will,” but instead it punched a period.

No, Lila was not ready. But her spirit is not bound by her former arrangement, and the exothermic consequences of that are only passive. Lila inhabits the Oakley ring, and she is free to compose herself. But reaching out between two parts of herself is not like writing a letter, and crafting a verse. It is not even like dance in the abstracted, highly symbolic sense. But it is a bit like orchestration. A series of non-verbal agreements to produce a result more beneficial to each party than to smolder away in a vehicle. A give and take between separate parts that may have been better off *dependent*. Breath in the lungs and a jolt to the brain. A wedge of force as a tool to exert leverage on a smoldering door. A swift kick with more force behind it than a human leg should be able to muster.

Lila shambles away from the ruptured shell of her burning Saturn and out into the driveway. Her feet scrape the asphalt, then stiffen. She takes in a breath like water trickling through a blocked drain. Then it is like writing a poem:

What fires wrought this heart?

This woman now disjointed

What will she be like?

Why did we make Lila

A concept to work toward

Are we building something here

Is this breath I'm taking

The first or the last

You made a hard choice

Mind the path it takes

Walk it while you can

Build and not tear down

What step do I take

Next?

Align my selves, assign my mind the throne

I'll be the voice behind the president

My arms will carry out what we decide

The thread I weave will keep us all alive

And Edge will line the bones of precedent

Lila holds her breath.

Her spirit's excess heat is siphoned away at her mind's direction and by her will expressed in extending her arm and spreading cracked and blackened fingers. The heat from the ring is converted into energy to serve Vita in repairing her body. Edge starves the flames and excises flesh that can't be rescued, clearing the way for Vita's threads to weave a sleeve of fabric all the way down to her wrist. Her hand remains a skeletal husk as a reminder to her selves of what happens when she plays with fire.

Lila exhales. It's a start. As her panic recedes, the flare of heat powering her healing recedes to a steady flicker. Her spirit finds this good, and her mind seeks to make that useful.

She proceeds with turning her turmoil into quanta of healing: electrical signals and chemical energy. She misses things. The brain is now mostly a tool, and one already damaged by the shock of her transformation. The heart pumps, but the production of white blood cells is forgotten. The bacteria in her gut and the acid in her stomach have not stopped working, but with less fuel for Vita she finds the gestalt of her separate pieces sending fingers of blended magic to pick out food in her digestive system and transmute it directly into the fuel of her spirit.

Fingers of magic that start within her stretch out loose from her body, snapping up asphalt and grass and vapor in the air and burning it as fuel to kickstart a new semblance of life. She recalls the sight of Thrast in the kitchen, claiming everything in sight as part of a new body. It occurs to her how easily he could have just taken the wealth of resources bound up in her body. It occurs to her that, during these moment of scrambling to recreate something recognizable out of her selves, she might not have the self-control to stop her selves from doing just that to any passers-by.

As if summoned by her thinking of him, Thrast returns. She feels him first, as she lets careful feelers of Extension stretch out from her. He descends to the end of the driveway as an armored nimbus of hastily manufactured flesh. His feet touch the asphalt and Lila looks him dead in his false eyes. Fury flares. Intent coils in her like a snake.

Stricken By a Revenant Glare



They move within Persaval's forced calm, and David's mind, maybe despite himself, tries to reconcile new experiences. Lake Michigan's beaches are often easily accessible, at least at points. In some places there are massive dunes, like the ones named after sleeping bears, and in others there's just a low grade that carries you down to the shore, to fine sands and, in the winter, sometimes frozen waves up to a mile out. Nature arresting itself, or trying to echo the passage of the glacier that carved the Great Lakes into the American Midwest in the first place. The Adamsons have visited these places. They would argue that the landscape is carved into them the way the Lakes were carved into their home state. But the approach to the shores of Qastra has neither dunes nor a gradual grade. That old trail becomes a hollowed out tunnel, which spares them some of the wind in some moments and in others dashes seaspray against the not-glass of Persaval's barrier. Then the tunnel opens out onto a stretch of shoreline strewn with debris like fallen trees and scraps of canvas.

And the storm is here.

The line anchored in David's chest pulls taught, lurching his vision towards the waterline. There, clouds race to engulf each other, howling with wind that whips against Persaval's wall and arguing in great barks of thunder that clap back from the cliffside. Their tumult seems bent on emerging a shape, something humanoid and mountainous and drawing at David's line with such a consistent weight that he stumbles out several steps ahead of Persaval and toward the shore.

"Is this the angel again?" he asks, but despite the bubble of stillness, with the noise of the outside and with his back to Persaval, the Sworn Sword doesn't seem to hear him. "Is it Thrast?"

He speaks the name, and the earth shakes. He falls on his ass.

Persaval's hand enters David's vision. David takes it and hauls himself up. It's strange, because Persaval's arm flexes back as if to pull him up, but David feels nothing pulling on his weight from the man. Only his own strength, and the insistent drawing tide of the line dragging him towards the shore. With some effort, he follows Persaval across the ruined beach, hardly ever managing to break what feels like eye contact with his impression of the thing that looms on the very edge of the boundary between sea and land, the thing it feels like is commanding him to throw himself into the deep.

When that vision is broken again it is by a little grassy curtain pulling closed between them, and a woman's furrowed brow coming very close to his face.

"You would not be welcome," she is saying to Persaval, "if you did not bring this poor clump of sod as your charge."

"I came to provide shelter from the storm."

"We have shelter enough," she says. "Now hush, I have something more pressing than the storm. Child, look me in the eyes."

David does, for a moment, before his eyes dart away against his will.

She coaxes his attention back to him with a comforting certainty. She has him count her fingers, then follow one back and forth across the periphery of his view. She feels at his lymph nodes and inspects his teeth.

"Vexed," she says. "Deeply. You need quiet, dark, and time."

David hears himself say, "Never helps much."

"You lose someone on the way?" she asks Persaval.

"Our tale is not simple."

"None are. Give me information. I will not be a poor host to this child. Was he struck? Were you chased here?"

David says, "Barrow knights. I pissed them off."

The woman puts a warm hand on the top of his head. "The knights nearest this shore have been At Rest for almost a decade," she says. "Did you wake them?"

Persaval says, "The Prophet is banished. We meant to give him an end like a death, but it seems Veneth will not let him go so readily. I fear the storm, and the waking Knights, are a response to what I and my fellows wrought."

"So you have carved out Mother's Soul after all?" the woman muses. "And what, did you make the boy watch?"

David says, "I've gotta make it stick."

She stares at him. Thunder crashes outside. A belch of sea spray splits the grass curtain. That draws her eyes back to Persaval. "Out," she says. "If you have some way to calm the winds then we will welcome the stillness."

Persaval catches David's eyes, like he's checking to see if David's going to be fine by himself. David does his best to return a look that asks 'does she look like she would hurt me?' A solemn nod, spinning on the ball of one foot, and ducking back out into the storm.

The woman pats at the skirts of her dress. She's almost unmentionably rustic, except the long tapered stick stuffed through her hair. That looks like a wand, polished and well-kept, but why in the hair?

She gestures, guiding David's eyes back further into this half-cave, half-hut home of hers. There's another grassy curtain doorway in the direction she points.

"There's a bed in the back," she says. "Go lie down. Try to rest. I will see what scraps I can coax together for you to eat. You're spent, boy."

"I don't know that there's a point to rest," David says. "What's coming is going to come whether I'm ready for it or not."

The woman's tone tightens in a way that David immediately recognizes. She says, "I am instructing you, boy. Not suggesting."

"You're a doctor."

She seems to chew on the word. "What's that? A healer of some kind?"

"Yeah," David says. "They're taught about the body and what hurts it, and they swear to use what they learn only to heal. 'Do no harm.'"

"That," the woman says, "is a harrowing oath."

David stares at the curtain the the far room. He can almost see his mother on the other side, taking a call from a patient with clinical care and poise then laying all the edge of her tongue on

verbally chastising Lila for some perceived slight. “They don’t bind you the same way where I’m from,” he says.

“So I am, if not by the same name. Now, bedrest.”

He’d been raised better than to ignore a doctor’s orders.



Persaval	Kella
 Augury	

The whole of the beach between the cliff-side tunnels and the settlers' caves breathes slowly: a gentle drift of breeze surrounded by hard stone and wild storm-winds. The stillness extends up into to sky, a ring without cloud cover that allows moonlight and glittering stars to witness the peaceful moment.

It's not a quiet peace. It is a strain to broaden the scope of a barrier to surround the whole tattered shoreline beyond the makeshift lee of the village's border. Persaval has to concentrate on his knowledge of the terrain, and forcing the Separation out so far means that he has very little he can affect within the confines of the barrier. It takes its toll on his body as well, makes him feel like a turtle withdrawn so far into his shell that he can hardly see the light outside. His heartbeat slows. His blood drains from his fingers and toes. Or it would, if he did not instinctively respond to the suppression of his will to live with a flare of Associative heat.

By now this is rote. But what is not rote is having to wrestle, not with the risk of giving up but with the temptation to push even further. 'Deeply vexed,' the caretaker woman had called David. Hardly more than a child, insisting on leaning into the same chill that Persaval has long since learned to call to heel. A boy, too young to know lost love or the toll of duty on years of living bone. For such a boy to be hounded by a storm called down by Veneth herself? It is, perhaps, all that Persaval can do to keep his heartflame from igniting into a blaze and bringing the full weight of his mastery to bear on the storm of Goletha. But it would be senseless to strangle a storm as a proxy for the sneer that's still peeled like a gaping wound across the back of Persaval's mind. Oaths are not made only to one's own heart.

All Oaths are public curses.

So Persaval, the Sworn Sword of Ea'river, stands in the middle of a beach, one foot anchored under a fallen tree's root, and holds open an eye for the storm over Goletha.



Left once more to the winnowing silence of her cave, Kella of Aspenwood again burrows completely into their furs. The visit from the wayward queen was long enough to bring Kella into themselves, to begin to feel again the awakening of her mind to the truth of the material even in a sanctuary she carved out with the express purpose to escape that truth.

These are the furs of creatures slain, if not by her hand then by the Extension of their will lived out in others' actions. Kolomaeri masters of craft cleaned the furs and lined them inside with the finest velvet. Much ado made about Kolomaer's weapons of war bearing the blessing of Enduring Quality. More impressive to Kella that the more tender craft of weaving is equally blessed: these furs of theirs cannot be soiled, and will remain clean and soft and warm until long after Kella's bones are dust. And yet, before the wonders of craft could bless them, first their material must be extracted, and the means to do that is violence. Hunt a creature for its fur. Use the rest or not, as you might. Capture another entirely for a quirk of something its body makes. Cultivate an entire category of being that lives within your domesticity and produces for you *silk*, which you extract with or without regard for the quiet, aching little lives of the beings who have been bent toward your will for production. What matters your care or tenderness for the lives that were taken? They have been taken beyond the veil, either of death or of servitude.

It is a difficult task, sometimes, to set all of that aside. Reduce down the history of the object to the effects of its material on your skin. Quiet an endless stream of thoughts before they can brush against the walls—walls you carved out after scaling a mountain while consumed by a fever that posed more threat to you than the torches and long knives of the frightened folk of Aspenwood, and Ea’river, and Qastra. It was not you who took their children. It was not you who—no. No.

Who is “you?” There is not a “you.” There is only the darkness, and the comforting heat, and a surrounding so soft that even skin is forgotten. Abandon the thought of a body. Abandon the thought of a self. If there is a “you,” then she is Veneth, as known by those who walk upon her. “You” are the land, the sea, the sky.

You are their angry congress, the storm turning in upon itself where the sea of Goletha assails the shores of Qastra.

You observe Persaval, where he stands in typical ostentatious opposition to your mounting wrath. He has closed himself to the touch of the Circle that claims him. You reflect on the rage that so clearly seethes within him, and its counterpart within your storm. Then you reflect on the Circle, and use that to consider the purpose of your observation.

The Circle is—or will be—restored. Mere has just bound herself again with Kella, that little waif hiding somewhere in her labyrinth of mountain caves. The Falcon God of Messengers now walks the Bridge that is sister to all worlds, where she seeks the kernel of love and yearning at the eye of Persaval’s personal storm. Then her attention will turn to Kolomaer, just as Kella’s thoughts had so recently turned, in order to draw poor Anshall back from the edge of his own reckoning with mortality.

You can return to the Eye in a moment. There are some things it is still worth taking note of elsewhere, first. Others cannot collect evidence at pace with you. You are, after all, a different kind of eye. All-seeing, when you want to be. And there is a question that you, like the Circle, would like to pose to Veneth.

“What will you do, now that you’re no longer held by the throat?”

You think you might already know the answer. You feel it in the deepness of yourself, echoing out to parts that can report the anxiety. Anxiety, that most elemental of feelings. The first report of a nerve to some central authority, before ever there was hope that there could be an answer. Is there anything outside the self? Will the self continue? Am “I” going to be okay? It can all start to feel so small.

But you mustn’t let your gaze drift too far out. There is beauty and horror to be found in the vast abyss of Being Without Self, but you are here with a goal to accomplish.

Ea’river.

Her cities have not yet noticed their grand prophet’s absence. Servants, Aligned or not, go about their appointed tasks with the same diligence as before. There is one exception you notice in Nailport, a city settled in one of the calmest of the Golethan bays. Within that port there is a single captain of the Qastran Legion, armed and armored with Kolomaeri steel that is as defiant to the weathering of time as his own body. This captain, Bendak, is embedded within the bureaucracy that maintains the safety of trade arriving at the port. Bendak, alerted by some tremor in his soul, looks up from a manifest and out into the fog of the sea. Straight at you. And while you, the Eye of All Things, are meeting many thousands of gazes at the moment this one seems to notice something *more* about what he has locked eyes with.

His gaze stretches long across the sea of Goletha—to trace its arc is no matter to you—and lands on (or passes through) the lantern light of a ship of the Gentlefishers who sail untouched by the turbulence of the sea. That crew of many masters shirks the gaze of your alarmed Captain Bendak, but their collective Second pauses and flinches, as if he feels the look prick itself between his shoulder blades. The sudden stop rattles the golden chains dangling from his collar, turning the pause into a quiet little bell-song of concern that is quickly silenced. The Second does not turn toward the source of that sense. Instead his gaze also snaps toward *you*, watching the Second and the Captain as they peer at you with a qualm churning up in your collective stomachs.

You can trace that line, if you wish, to where you know it leads. Qastra, buried alive by its oaths, and the looming storm. But first...

Those far High Halls of Kolomaer have their own eyes peering out. Kolomaer alone retains records of its contracts with Lost Naris. Kolomaer alone, that nation where no craft may be permitted to pass away, refuses the pretence that Ea'river and Qastra long since accepted: that there was never a land of masked gods who served and guided the other nations in equal turn. Kolomaer alone, and the Circle bound to a Falcon and her Sparrow, who honor, as they can, their Sworn Sword's oath to remember what even Veneth has abandoned. Anshall's face, slumped and hardly meeting the eyes of his courtiers, does not turn to you, but it does occasionally slip out into the other fog, the one that shrouds the ruins of what was.

Lost Naris itself is barred to your sight. The will of that prophet, and the wills he bent towards the scouring that occurred, befouled the Marshall's Gates and blinded Veneth to all of Naris when they broke the countenance of the gods. But another lost nation, abandoned not only by Veneth but her own people, is easy for you to spy. The high stone walls of the island fortress Goletha stand empty.

You complete your survey, and the question persists. There is an Accepted Model of Veneth held by scholars and heads of state across her breadth, and it is thus: as with the Paradigms, there are only ever *Five Nations* of note. Some new nations may rise as others fall, so there may be some period of transition between them, but in the end the equilibrium of the world is for there to be a balance of the Five against each other. Thrast is *breaking* that model. Goletha disappeared from the nations of the world long ago. After it did, Ea'river emerged as a new nation, birthed out of the Wilds with its wealth of amber and its love of history. Then Naris was struck down, a militant action by several of the Five that argued Naris was a threat to the balance of Veneth. But then no new nation emerged to take Naris' place.

Then Qastra faded, bleached white in the sun. Not really gone, but neither truly a nation any longer.

And yet Thrast flourished, Veneth persisted, and the expected cycle of emergence did not continue.

So the theory became, among those who could dare to debate the movements of the world from their corners, that Thrast must be somehow bending Veneth against her natural course, warping her into some new and terrible shape that would ultimately spell the end of Veneth as we know her.

The Circle does not believe in the 'Accepted Model,' exactly. Or, that's not why you have risked everything and un-spooled yourself into the ether of all things in order to see what has happened now that Thrast has been cut off from Veneth. It's more personal than that for each of you. Or, for the rest of the Circle. You, Kella, have a hard time reconciling with the *personal*. You don't trust where your mind goes when you start thinking too long about what 'Kella' wants.

So you stay wrapped up in the comfort of life outside life and project yourself into Veneth.

But even then it's hard to retain that distance in the end. Can you be sure that the panic and loneliness you think you feel pinging out from Veneth herself is really the soul of your world, or is that your own, crying out from your own singular abyss?

If Thrast is really gone, and he was truly bending Veneth out of her natural shape, then why does Veneth feel like she's curling in on herself worse than ever? What if cutting Thrast out of the world is what kills Veneth, not saves her? What if that unspeakable dominance of his will upon the world was *everything that Veneth wanted*, not just another abuse he visits on the largest and most consequential of his victims?

Kella sends along the bond of the Circle to Mere that no, Veneth does not seem to be recovering in Thrast's absence. There are no signs of some new people and land clawing its way free from the Wilds. She reserves for herself her deeper fears, tucking them away into a quiet corner of her abyss, before becoming *you* again.

You see Persaval facing the storm like it is a giant he means to slay. Dermike is in his hand, flickering occasionally with a pale unconscious flame. But Persaval's gaze is not so striking here. It's that Captain Bendak, and the Second, and the storm itself, and the company of awakened Legionnaires casting themselves hundreds of feet down from their cliff-side keep to land in sickening, reconstituting heaps just outside the glassy eye of Persaval's own *personal* storm. But they're hardly looking at Persaval.

No, they're all looking at the boy who has emerged into the storm. The torn shirt, the sleek little black brick in his hand, and the look in his eyes as he peers into the storm. This is the boy Mere spoke of. This is David. *You* cannot touch him. You become transfixed in your furs in your cave in the mountains. He, like you, watches all of this unfolding. But he cannot have the smallest measure of your context for it all. For him this is something else. You don't need to touch him to feel it. Your Extension reacts on its own. It wraps itself in the eddies of his wake.

All of Veneth feels like she is staring at David, and he is staring back, and you can see that what he is searching for and finding in the gaze that meets him is Thrast, in all his imperious wrath. You see a boy incredulous at a brand new world that hates him.

He says, "Fine," and though the noise of his voice should be buried in the Cacophony of All Things it sounds like a whipcrack in your ears. He takes another step towards the storm, and the resolution on his face doesn't look like bravery. It looks like he's wrapping himself in furs and peeling himself apart for someone else's purpose.

You mutter to yourself aloud the things you spoke to Mere. Stricken, indeed.



He can feel the eyes. The boy, pathetic in Lila's memory, some victim of the folly of the Sword and his saboteurs. That young man should be of no concern in the face of all the rest there is to do. And yet, Thrast feels *watched*.

Thrust descends to where Lila waits, having wrought some ruin for herself and bearing only malice towards him. He drifts down to either cajole or console her—he is not sure which—but piercing through her own glare are the eyes of her brother.

His hair tousled by a wind Thrast does not feel. His cheeks lit by flames Thrast cannot see. If this boy, David, is somewhere within Veneth's embrace then the location is barred to Thrast. But the boy, he can see.

There is anger there, and fear, but they do not even nudge the irises of David's eyes.

In a contest of wills, there is often a benefit to knowing how you will meet the gaze of your opponent. Consider their strategy, and the limits of their perspective, and pick them apart as they try to hold their own in the confrontation.

Even against the likes of the Realmshorn Thrast has been a master of commanding the flow of an exchange. But for some reason, he can come to no conclusion about how to position himself in the face of this boy. Whatever binds the two of them does nothing to link their thoughts. It leaves no vulnerability to the boy for Thrast to slip a creeper through.

David asks, "Are you worth all this?"

And Thrast feels his manufactured body flare and become ashes. David and Lila and Earth vanish to him, and all that Thrast knows is the storm-winds that raised him as a child dashing the casing of his amber pendant to the sands.

END PART ONE
